What Killed the ERA?

The Role of Entrepreneurs in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy

Hong Wang

Boston University
Department of Economics
hongxi@bu.edu

June 30, 2026

Abstract

Despite the overwhelming congressional support and a national feminist resurgence in 1972, the Equal Rights Amendment died three states short of ratification by 1982. I estimate Phyllis Schlafly's causal influence on that defeat by exploiting topographic and geochemical variation in exposure to her CBS Spectrum radio and television commentaries. In Illinois, a one-standard-deviation increase in legislators' CBS FM exposure reduced ERA support by 18.4 pp, while television and AM exposure increased adoption of Schlafly's anti-ERA framing. Across five non-ratifying battleground states, exposed counties saw a 0.21 standard-deviation decline in sentiment toward women's rights. The results suggest how entrepreneur-led cultural backlash, amplified by mass media, helped kill the ERA.

Acknowledgments: I am grateful to my advisors Melissa Dell, James Feigenbaum, Martin Fiszbein, Claudia Goldin, and Robert Margo for their invaluable mentorship throughout this project. I thank Edward Glaeser, Brian Knight, Danielle Williamson, and seminar participants at Harvard and the LSE for helpful advice. I thank Ryan (Muhammad) Adriansyah, Daniel Dugan, Keyi Liu and Hendra Adi Putra for their excellent research assistance and attention to detail. Special thanks to Jasmine Sykes-Kunk and other archivists at the Brown University Library for helping me access the John Birch Society Collection; and James Feigenbaum for the Legacy Collection 1967-2016 set of Phyllis Schlafly Reports.

> "The single biggest obstacle I had to overcome were the words equal rights. Who can be against equal rights?"
>
> Phyllis Schlafly, 2000 Eagle Council Training

The Equal Rights Amendment (ERA) was introduced in Congress every year from 1923 to 1972. The Republican Party platform endorsed the ERA from 1940 to 1980, and the Democratic Party platform began endorsing it in 1944. In October 1971, the ERA passed the House overwhelmingly, 354 to 24. In March 1972, it sailed through the Senate, 84 to 8. After nearly half a century stuck in committee, the amendment appeared to have become mainstream. Yet by 1982, the ERA was dead, three states short of ratification.

Historians and participants have offered competing answers for why the ERA failed. Most historians credit Phyllis Schlafly, who united the anti-ERA movement behind STOP ERA in 1972 and later reorganized it as Eagle Forum in 1975 (Critchlow 2005; Mansbridge 1986; Spruill 2017). Feminist leaders, by contrast, emphasized the insurance industry. Gloria Steinem and Eleanor Smeal argued that health insurance "stood to lose billions if the ERA forced it to stop charging women more for less coverage" and that the industry "had lobbyists in every state capital". They maintained that "Phyllis Schlafly and her antifeminist homemakers" were "brought in to cover for legislators" who were already "voting against the ERA anyway" (Steinem and Smeal 2020).[1] The ERA had potential implications for auto insurance, life insurance, and annuities that could disadvantage women (Mansbridge 1986).

Support for the ERA was wide but shallow. Many Americans could endorse equality of rights in the abstract while opposing concrete implications that opponents attached to the federal ERA: women in combat, changes to alimony and child support, publicly funded abortions, federal courts, policing, and the transfer of authority over family law from states to federal judges. The question is how an Amendment that seemed mainstream became attached to a set of concrete threats powerful enough to stop ratification. Despite decades of debate, no quantitative evidence has adjudicated between these competing accounts.

I estimate Schlafly's influence on legislative behavior and public opinion using variation in CBS reception generated by broadcast physics. TV and FM exposure vary with topographic obstruction of broadcast signals, while AM exposure varies with soil conductivity, which I isolate using a geochemical instrument. The identifying comparison is between legislative districts and counties in the same pivotal states that differed in predicted access to Schlafly's CBS platform for physical reasons, not because of observed political demand for anti-ERA messages. I use these reception differences to test whether differential exposure shifted legislative votes, the language legislators used to debate the ERA, and public sentiment. I focus on five pivotal states that never ratified the ERA despite sustained pro-ERA campaigns: Florida, Illinois, Missouri, North Carolina, and Oklahoma. The five pivotal states were the critical battlegrounds where small shifts in public sentiment or legislative behavior could have mattered most. Section 2 develops the propagation models and identification strategy in detail.

The main empirical analysis, in Section 3, uses Illinois legislative debates and roll-call

[1] Gloria Steinem co-founded *Ms.* magazine in 1971. Eleanor Smeal was president of the National Organization for Women (NOW) from 1977 to 1982 and again from 1985 to 1987.

votes. Illinois offers the strongest test because it links CBS exposure directly to the institutional outcome that determined ratification. A one standard deviation increase in CBS FM coverage within a legislative district reduced legislators' probability of voting yes on the ERA by 18.4 percentage points. Exposure also changed how legislators talked about the amendment. A one standard deviation increase in CBS TV exposure increased legislators' adoption of Schlafly's ERA framing by 5.0 percentage points, measured by semantic similarity between their speeches and her newsletters; using the geochemical IV for CBS AM exposure increased adoption by 5.3 percentage points.[2]

The second analysis, in Section 4, asks whether the Illinois result is mirrored in public opinion across the five pivotal states. I treat the ANES estimates as corroborating evidence rather than the paper's primary causal test because the available survey waves provide limited pre-treatment leverage for a conventional pre-trends assessment. Within that constraint, counties exposed to CBS FM radio after 1974 experienced a 0.21 standard deviation decline in sentiment toward women's rights, relative to unexposed counties. CBS TV and AM radio do not produce a comparable shift in women's-rights sentiment, and neither CBS TV nor radio significantly changes sentiment toward the women's liberation movement. Scope tests across other ANES outcomes show that the CBS FM effect is not a general conservative shift: most racial, ideological, and affective outcomes do not move, while the one broader outcome that does move—rights of the accused—matches Schlafly's explicit effort to link the ERA to crime, policing, and courts.

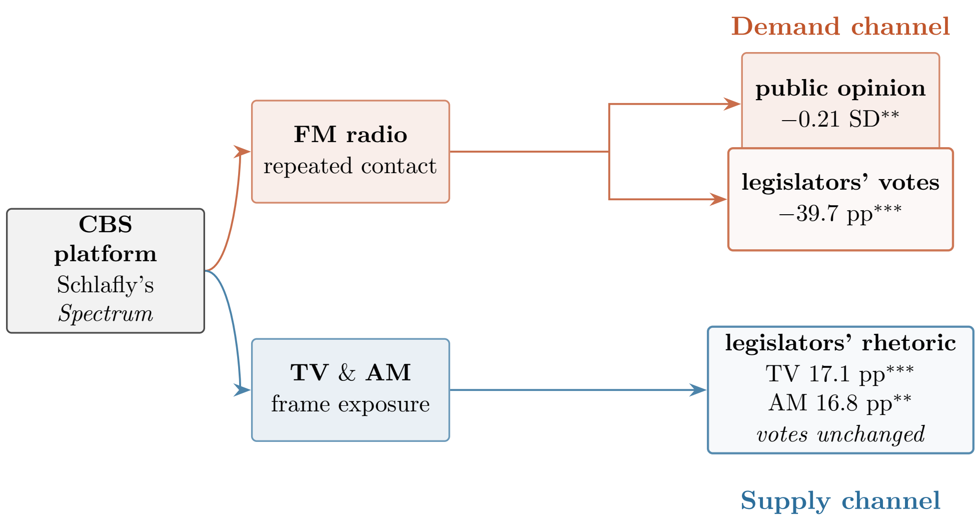

Figure 1: Two-channel mechanism. FM exposure moves public opinion and legislators' votes; TV and AM exposure move legislators' rhetoric without moving votes. Raw coefficients not adjusted by standard deviation or percentile. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

[2]In raw coverage terms, the CBS FM coefficient is 39.7 pp. Because the 10th and 90th percentiles of CBS FM coverage span the full range, 0% to 100%, this raw coefficient is also the 10th-to-90th percentile effect; see Table 15. For legislators' adoption of Schlafly's framing, the raw CBS TV coefficient is 17.1 pp when estimated alongside FM exposure. In the TV+AM IV specification, the CBS TV coefficient is 19.6 pp, corresponding to 5.0 pp per standard deviation or 12.2 pp going from the 10th to 90th percentile, 37.9% to 100% land-area coverage. The raw CBS AM IV coefficient is 16.8 pp, corresponding to 5.3 pp per standard deviation or 12.1 pp across the 10th-to-90th percentile gap.

Figure 1 summarizes the paper's two-channel interpretation and the empirical hierarchy. The strongest evidence comes from Illinois, where FM exposure moved legislators' votes and TV and AM exposure changed legislative rhetoric, consistent with demand and supply channels operating inside the institution that decided ratification. The five-state ANES results then show that the same FM channel is visible in mass attitudes, providing corroborating evidence that the voting effect reflected changes in the political environment legislators faced. Effects persist after controlling for pre-existing conservative networks, religious composition, and ANES respondent and legislator characteristics. Moreover, I find that Illinois legislators' professional affiliation with the insurance industry had no effect on their vote for the ERA, suggestive evidence contrary to the insurance lobby hypothesis.

Section 5 explains why Schlafly's arguments resonated. Schlafly's core anti-ERA repertoire–claims about women in combat, alimony, child support, Social Security, insurance, bathrooms, prisons, and courts–did not originate with her. These arguments had circulated for decades among liberal–labor opponents of the amendment. Schlafly's innovation was to match older arguments to a new audience of homemakers and religious conservatives and then amplify that match through CBS. I call this process cultural matching: the movement of pre-existing arguments to a newly receptive audience through a platform that makes the match politically consequential.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 1 provides historical background on the ERA's path to congressional passage and Schlafly's construction of the STOP ERA campaign. Section 2 describes the exposure measures for Schlafly's CBS commentaries. Section 3 presents the main empirical evidence from Illinois legislative behavior and reports the insurance-affiliation result. Section 4 presents corroborating public-opinion evidence from the five pivotal non-ratifying states. Section 5 traces the historical origins of Schlafly's anti-ERA repertoire and develops the cultural-matching interpretation. Section 6 concludes.

1 Background

1.1 The Long Road to the ERA

The ERA is a brief document whose core text originated with suffragist Alice Paul in 1923. Paul revised the language in 1943, and that version became Section 1 of the amendment Congress passed in 1972: "Equality of rights under the law shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of sex."[3] To become part of the US Constitution, the federal ERA had to pass 38 out of 50 state legislatures within seven years of passing Congress.[4] By the end of 1972, 22 states had ratified the ERA, and eight more joined

[3]Paul's original 1923 text, initially named "the Lucretia Mott Amendment," read: "men and women shall have equal rights throughout the United States and every place subject to its jurisdiction." The full resolution passed by Congress added two further sections: an enforcement clause granting Congress implementation authority and a two-year effective date provision.

[4]The landmark, *Coleman v. Miller* (1939), clarified that amendments to the US Constitution are pending before the states if Congress does not set a deadline. Congress's practice of seven-year deadlines, though not explicitly given in Article V, started with the 18th Amendment (1917) on prohibition. Since the 27th Amendment's ratification in 1992, despite its Congressional passage in 1789, some legal scholars argue that under a strict interpretation of Article V, an amendment becomes part of Constitution after the 38th state

in 1973. Ratification then slowed sharply: between 1974 and 1977, only five additional states joined, bringing the total to 35. No additional states adopted the ERA despite congressional approval of a three-year extension. Five states even rescinded their ratification.[5]

Some states had already adopted sex-equality provisions in their constitutions or through state statute. Illinois is especially important for this paper because its 1970 Constitution states: "The equal protection of the laws shall not be denied or abridged on account of sex by the State or its units of local government and school districts" (Article I, Section 18, 1970 Illinois Constitution).[6] Illinois voters approved that constitution by a wide margin (57.3%) in 1970, but the Illinois General Assembly never ratified the federal ERA during the decade after congressional passage.[7]

Support for a state-level equal rights provision did not automatically translate into support for a federal amendment. As Mansbridge (1986) argues, a federal ERA would have shifted authority over family law from the states to federal judges. Because the federal government also controls the military, opponents could connect the federal ERA directly to fears of drafting women into combat. Had the federal ERA passed, it likely would not have produced either the immediate radical changes opponents feared or the short-term economic gains proponents promised, given its limitation to government action and the evolving sex-discrimination jurisprudence of the 14th Amendment and Title VII. Its primary impact would have been long-term: a constitutional symbol guiding future judicial and legislative action Mansbridge (1986).

Despite the long campaign for passage, many Americans in 1972 were neutral or knew little about the ERA. On its face, the amendment seemed beneficial, if not innocuous. National support was roughly 57% for, 32% against, and 11% with no opinion throughout the 1970s (Mansbridge 1986). Yet state-level referendum campaigns showed that public support could collapse once opponents attached the ERA to specific legal consequences. In states where a standalone state ERA provision went to referendum, polling showed majority support before the campaign, but the actual vote went the other way.[8] These discrepancies may reflect voters changing their minds when confronted with concrete implications, or polls failing to sample the newly mobilized constituencies anti-ERA organizers had awakened. Either way, the pattern helps explain why anti-ERA organizers emphasized military service, family law, federal courts, and sex-specific benefits rather than the amendment's abstract equality language.

The gap between nominal support and concrete issue opposition matters for interpreting the ANES evidence. A broad decline in stated ERA approval is not inconsistent with high nominal support in 1976. Instead, it suggests that the ERA's meaning changed as the amendment became attached to concrete issues such as military service, family law, courts, policing, and the scope of federal power. The empirical design does not treat the national decline in ERA approval as the estimand. Instead, the design asks whether differential

---

ratifies and that *Coleman* gave Congress the power to modify the deadline (Held, Herndon, and Stager 1997).

[5]The legal validity of rescission is unresolved as the Supreme Court dismissed the issue as moot in 1982.

[6]The semantic similarity between the Illinois and federal provision is 0.828.

[7]The Illinois General Assembly imposed a three-fifths majority threshold solely for passing the federal ERA. Illinois was the only Northern state not to ratify.

[8]New York: 57% no (1975); New Jersey: 51% no (1975); Florida: 56% no (1978); Iowa: 55% no (1980); Maine: 63% no (1984) (Mansbridge 1986).

exposure to Schlafly's CBS platform moved specific attitudes and legislative behavior relative to that broader national shift.

Legal doctrine also offered other means to much of what the ERA sought to accomplish. Courts had just begun to use the 5th Amendment for federal laws and the 14th Amendment for state laws to prohibit sex discrimination by government, as they had long done for race. *Reed v. Reed* (1971), the first sex-discrimination case to use the equal protection clause of the 14th Amendment, had just been decided, and *Frontiero v. Richardson* (1973), the first to use the 5th Amendment, would soon follow. By the late 1970s, the Supreme Court had used the 14th Amendment to invalidate nearly all the discriminatory laws Congress intended the ERA to address (Mansbridge 1986). The narrowing of the ERA's practical scope raised a question legislators found increasingly difficult to dismiss: if the courts were already doing what the ERA was designed to do, what concrete benefits remained—and were they worth handing the Supreme Court new constitutional language to interpret?

Of the 15 non-ratifying states, Mansbridge (1986) characterizes ten as "Southern or Mormon," where ratification was unlikely to begin with: Alabama, Arizona, Arkansas, Georgia, Louisiana, Mississippi, Nevada, South Carolina, Utah, and Virginia. Yet even in these states, opposition was constructed rather than inevitable. Segregationists like Senator Strom Thurmond (R-South Carolina) supported the ERA in 1972, and Alabama Governor George Wallace had endorsed it in 1968. Schlafly personally lobbied both Wallace and the LDS church leadership to reverse their positions, and both did (Spruill 2017). That leaves five states where ratification was genuinely contested. In addition to the four identified by Mansbridge (1986)—Florida, Illinois, North Carolina, and Oklahoma—I add Missouri, where Schlafly founded STOP ERA and recorded her CBS commentaries at KMOX St. Louis. The five pivotal states never ratified the ERA despite sustained pro-ERA campaigns, making them the critical battlegrounds where Schlafly's influence would have mattered most. Figure 17 shows how narrow the final margin was: small shifts in public sentiment or legislative behavior in a handful of pivotal states could decisively determine the outcome.[9] The political opportunity, then, was not to oppose equality in the abstract but to change what the ERA meant.

1.2 Stop Taking Our Privileges (STOP) ERA

Phyllis Schlafly supplied that alternative meaning. Phyllis Schlafly (born: August 1924, died: September 2016) was a Catholic, a suburban mother of six who was active in local Republican politics and who ran unsuccessfully in Illinois for the US House in 1952 (and 1970), and the wife of a prominent St. Louis attorney (Harvard JD), Fred Schlafly. She received a BA and JD from Washington University, respectively in 1944 and 1978, and an MA in 1945 from Radcliffe College. She was a most untraditional traditional woman, one who made a career out of defending the right of women not to have one.

Schlafly's ascent to the national spotlight began during the 1964 presidential campaign, when she wrote her first self-published book, *A Choice Not An Echo.* The book sold millions of copies and helped make Barry Goldwater the Republican nominee.[10] Schlafly was a

[9] These pivotal states may have unobservable characteristics that may not generalize to less contested states.

[10] In her book, Schlafly sold Goldwater as the only candidate who could stop the "coastal elite kingmaker"

member of the John Birch Society (JBS), though she consistently denied it. In a December 1959 letter to Verne Kaub of the American Council of Christian Laymen, Schlafly wrote that she and her husband "both joined promptly after the Chicago meeting," and the February 1960 JBS Bulletin described her as "a very loyal member" (Lazar 2020).[11] She resigned from the JBS in 1964 to prevent *A Choice Not An Echo* from being associated with the organization during the Goldwater campaign. In an August 1964 letter, JBS founder Robert Welch confirmed that the decision not to promote the book through JBS bookstores was made at Schlafly's request. Even so, individual JBS members bought and distributed more than 300,000 copies in California alone (Dallek 2023; Lazar 2020).

By 1964, Schlafly had risen to First Vice President of the National Federation of Republican Women (NFRW). After Goldwater's landslide defeat, moderate and liberal Republicans, including Elly Peterson and George Romney, moved to contain her influence. In May 1967, she lost the NFRW presidency to the establishment's preferred candidate, Gladys O'Donnell, in a bitterly contested campaign. Schlafly and roughly 3,000 furious supporters walked out of the convention and launched their own conservative movement, using the *Phyllis Schlafly Report* newsletter and an Eagle Trust Fund to finance their work (Spruill 2017). Her expertise was in foreign policy and defense, not domestic issues. The first issue of the *Phyllis Schlafly Report*, released in August 1967, criticized the proposed handover of the Panama Canal by the United States and ended with a poem decrying O'Donnell's victory in the NFRW election.

The Republican women's establishment was led by pro-business and professional women who had originally championed the ERA. Schlafly's followers, by contrast, were often traditional, religious women who felt shut out by that establishment. As Schlafly framed it, the party's liberals would not give their side anything at all—"not even the crumb of a non-paid woman's position with practically no power" (Spruill 2017). When the ERA became a national issue in 1972, Schlafly did not need to build a movement from scratch. She could redirect a network forged through persistent institutional exclusion.

Schlafly was not initially opposed to the ERA. In December 1971, friends in Connecticut invited her to debate the amendment; she demurred, saying she did not know which side she was on. Schlafly "figured [the] ERA was something between innocuous and mildly helpful." Her host insisted and sent materials for her to study. Around the same time, Shirley Spellerberg, a conservative talk-radio host in Florida and a friend of Schlafly's, urged her to examine the amendment's implications. Spellerberg later expressed deep frustration over Schlafly's initial apathy. She believed they could have stopped the amendment in Congress and regretted that she simply "couldn't get [Schlafly] to move" earlier (Spruill 2017).

Schlafly's first anti-ERA issue of the *Phyllis Schlafly Report*, published in February 1972, centered on two claims: the ERA would require drafting women and would abolish women's right to child support and alimony. In March 1972, PSR subscriber Ann Patterson called Schlafly to report that the Oklahoma legislature had paused its ERA vote after the newsletter was distributed to legislators (Critchlow 2005; DePue 2011). In September 1972, Schlafly

Republicans, who were suppressing true conservative voices and forcing a moderate, internationalist agenda.

[11] When asked directly about her membership in her oral history interview, Schlafly said only that she had attended "a seminar that Robert Welch spoke at in Chicago" (DePue 2011).

founded STOP ERA in St. Louis, Missouri (Spruill 2017).

By the November 1972 PSR, she had expanded her arsenal. She claimed that the ERA would raise insurance premiums, lower Social Security benefits, eliminate separate sports teams and prisons, and force unisex restrooms. Schlafly cited Harvard Law professor Paul Freund, who wrote in 1971 that "A doctrinaire equality, then, is apparently the theme of the Amendment ... life insurance commissioners may not continue to approve lower life insurance premiums for women (based on greater life expectancy)" (Freund 1971).

The November 1972 PSR also sharpened Schlafly's cultural attack. She wrote that "the women's liberationists ... motive is totally radical ... hate men, marriage, and children ... out to destroy morality and the family." In the same issue, she acknowledged the professional-women case for the amendment: "It is easy to see why the business and professional women are supporting the Equal Rights Amendment ... We support you in your efforts to eliminate all injustices, and we believe this can be done through the Civil Rights Act and the Equal Employment Opportunity Act [1972]." Starting in 1973, she included a separate anti-ERA supplement in her monthly newsletter, dispensing arguments and tactics for defeating the amendment. The newsletter became Schlafly's primary weapon for attacking the ERA and coordinating with her "troops."

To lead her state-level campaigns, Schlafly personally selected STOP ERA chairwomen from overlapping contacts in the National Federation of Republican Women (NFRW), National Council of Catholic Women (NCCW), Daughters of the American Revolution (DAR), the Goldwater campaign, and other conservative organizations. Some chairs acknowledged using John Birch Society connections to recruit supporters. Dorothy (Dot) Malone Slade, a JBS member who knew Schlafly through the NFRW, led North Carolina and invited fellow JBS members to help. Beverly Findley, a former JBS member, led Oklahoma with Ann Patterson and worked with JBS members to plan anti-ERA hearings and recruit supporters.

In 1975, STOP ERA joined forces with Women Who Want to be Women (WWWW), a sister organization founded by Lottie Beth Hobbs, a Church of Christ leader from Fort Worth, Texas. WWWW mobilized fundamentalist Protestant women in the South—a constituency Schlafly's Catholic, Midwestern network could not easily reach.

Schlafly's mobilization extended to other faiths. In Utah, a majority of 1972 legislative candidates supported the amendment regardless of party, and the LDS church president initially declined to take a position. After Schlafly met with Mormon leaders, however, church opposition hardened rapidly: a *Church News* editorial denounced the amendment, legislators withdrew their support, and ratification was easily defeated in 1974. By 1976, the LDS officially declared the ERA a "moral issue" and directed members to work actively for its defeat, generating disproportionate lobbying pressure even in states where Mormons were a small minority (Spruill 2017).[12]

When Schlafly began her campaign in 1972, her network was largely Catholic, with some Orthodox Jewish support. Yet conservative Catholics were divided: nuns' organizations and an ad hoc group called Catholic Women for the ERA actively supported ratification, while major Catholic lay organizations, including the NCCW in which Schlafly had long been

[12]In 1977, JBS leader John F. McManus claimed having members "in leadership positions in every state where the ERA was scotched." JBS women in Utah organized against the ERA since December 1972 through a front group called HOTDOG (Humanitarians Opposed to Degrading Our Girls) (Spruill 2017).

active, opposed the amendment. Ultimately, church membership, not class or education, was the strongest predictor of anti-ERA activism: 98% of anti-ERA activists claimed church membership, compared to 31–48% of pro-ERA activists (Spruill 2017). Schlafly had to construct the religious coalition against the ERA rather than inheriting a pre-existing bloc. She helped unite theologically hostile denominations around shared anxieties about gender roles, converting latent religious conservatism into coordinated political action.

Starting in 1973, Schlafly became a commentator on CBS's radio program Spectrum. From 1973 to 1978, every week, she "would drive down to KMOX [St. Louis] and record two commentaries, which then went out all over the world on the CBS Network" (DePue 2011). Spectrum began as a five-minute nationally syndicated radio program that aired repeatedly throughout the day on both AM and FM stations. The program brought commentators from across the political spectrum to offer opinions on, or debate, controversial national issues. In 1974, Spectrum expanded to television as a segment on *CBS Morning News* (7–8 AM).[13] In 1975, Spectrum became a standalone show, airing on both TV and radio until 1978.

2 Measuring Exposure to Schlafly's CBS Commentaries

To test whether Schlafly's CBS appearances changed public opinion and legislative behavior, I construct measures of predicted CBS TV, FM, and AM reception. The design exploits physical variation in broadcast propagation rather than observed viewing or listening. For TV and FM, the relevant variation comes from topography (Longley and Rice 1968; Olken 2009). Radio waves in the FM and TV frequency range (20 MHz to 20 GHz) are obstructed or diverted by hills, valleys, and buildings. Terrain obstructions create geographic variation in whether households can receive a station's signal, even at the same distance from the transmitter. A county on one side of a river valley may receive a strong signal from a distant tower, while a neighboring county across the valley receives weak or no signal.

I digitized TV tower parameters from the 1972-73 Television Factbook, updated as of March 30, 1972, eight days after the ERA passed the Senate. For each TV station in the US, the Factbook records the tower's geographic coordinates, height, visual and audio power, and channel (frequency). I analogously digitized CBS FM and AM radio tower parameters from the 1972 Broadcasting Yearbook, updated as of November 15, 1971. I input the TV and FM tower parameters into the Irregular Terrain Model (ITM) (Longley and Rice 1968), which predicts TV and radio signal strength in decibels-milliwatt (dBm) from each transmitter to any receiver location using the topographical elevation map between them.

The ITM operates in two modes. Point-to-point mode computes signal attenuation from the actual terrain elevation profile between a transmitter and a specific receiver, accounting for hills, valleys, and obstructions along the path. Area prediction mode instead estimates those terrain parameters statistically from a single terrain-irregularity parameter, Δh, the interdecile range of terrain elevations in the surrounding area, without requiring a specific receiver location (Hufford, Longley, and Kissick 1982).

[13] From archival CBS transcripts, I found that Schlafly made 14 appearances from January to October 1974, though none explicitly on the ERA. In 1975, Schlafly appeared once as an ERA news story, not commentator, when Spectrum had ended as a segment. I have no Spectrum transcripts outside of 1974 CBS Morning News.

The two ITM modes correspond to the two reception settings in this paper. For TV, I use point-to-point mode because rooftop antennas receive television signals at fixed household locations; I therefore compute the terrain profile from each TV tower to each county centroid. For FM radio, I use area prediction mode because Spectrum aired repeatedly throughout the day and could reach listeners in moving vehicles. The ITM in area mode treats the car-radio receiver as randomly sited at a 2m mobile height within terrain characterized by Δh, computed over a 30 km radius (Table 20). For TV, I use a 9m rooftop receiver height and a threshold of -55 dBm for reliable VHF reception (47 CFR §73.683, 56 dBu). For FM radio, I use a threshold of -47 dBm for FM city-grade reception (47 CFR §73.315, 70 dBu).[14] I code a county as "exposed" to a given network if its centroid receives signal strength above the relevant threshold from any network-affiliated station.

AM requires a different exposure measure. At AM broadcast frequencies, wavelengths are $\sim 300m$—long enough that signals diffract around terrain and propagate as ground waves following the Earth's curvature.[15] Topographic elevation, which identifies the TV and FM effects, is therefore not the relevant source of variation. AM signal attenuation instead depends on soil conductivity along the transmission path. I model AM propagation using the LFMF ground-wave engine (DeMinco 1986; DeMinco 1999), implementing the Millington mixed-path method over $n = 50$ path segments (Table 20). Because AM ground-wave attenuation varies gradually with soil conductivity rather than exhibiting sharp terrain-driven cutoffs, I treat AM signal strength as a continuous measure.[16]

Figure 2 summarizes why TV/FM and AM require different propagation models.

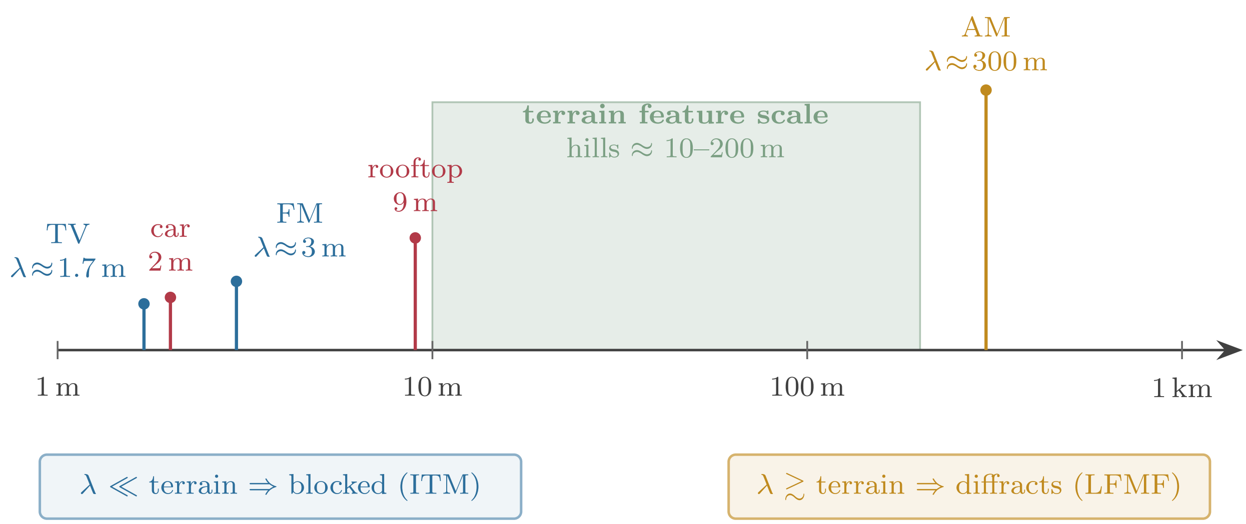

Figure 2: Wavelength scale. TV and FM wavelengths are small relative to terrain and receiver height, so elevation can block reception. AM's wavelength is much larger, so identification comes from soil conductivity rather than terrain.

[14] To convert dBu to dBm, I use the formula: $P_{\text{dBm}} = E_{\text{dB}\mu\text{V/m}} - 77.2 + G - 20\log_{10}(f_{\text{MHz}})$, which is a rearrangement of Equation 20 in Sanders 2010. I assume a frequency of 100 MHz for FM radio with G = 0 dBi (car antenna whip) and Channel 7 (174 MHz) for TV with G = 10 dBi (rooftop antenna).

[15] Wavelength is $\lambda = c/f$. TV at 174 MHz has $\lambda \approx 1.7m$; FM at 100 MHz has $\lambda \approx 3m$; AM at 1 MHz has $\lambda \approx 300m$.

[16] Discretizing the AM signal causes the strong first-stage F-statistic to collapse.

2.1 Threats to the CBS Exposure Measure

The core empirical challenge is that CBS exposure is predicted, not randomly assigned. Households that receive CBS signals may differ systematically from those that do not, and those differences could independently predict ERA attitudes. Urban counties, for example, may be flatter and therefore receive stronger signals while also being more liberal; conservative rural counties may cluster in mountainous areas with weaker reception. Tower placement also reflects broadcaster choices rather than random assignment. CBS affiliates chose locations, power, height, and frequency for commercial reasons, and those choices could correlate with the political geography of ERA support.

Three selection threats are especially important. First, Schlafly's supporters might have sorted into CBS-covered areas, though TV and FM radio infrastructure predates her campaign. Second, CBS might have placed towers in areas more receptive to Schlafly's message. Third, Schlafly's pre-existing network may cluster geographically, conflating CBS exposure with grassroots organizing.

The identifying assumption is that, conditional on controls, differences in signal strength between nearby counties reflect broadcast physics rather than systematic differences in unobserved ERA attitudes. For TV and FM, the assumption is most credible when otherwise comparable counties differ because terrain blocks the path from a transmitter to one county while leaving the path to another unobstructed. Figure 3 illustrates this identifying comparison and shows why the same terrain variation does not identify AM exposure.

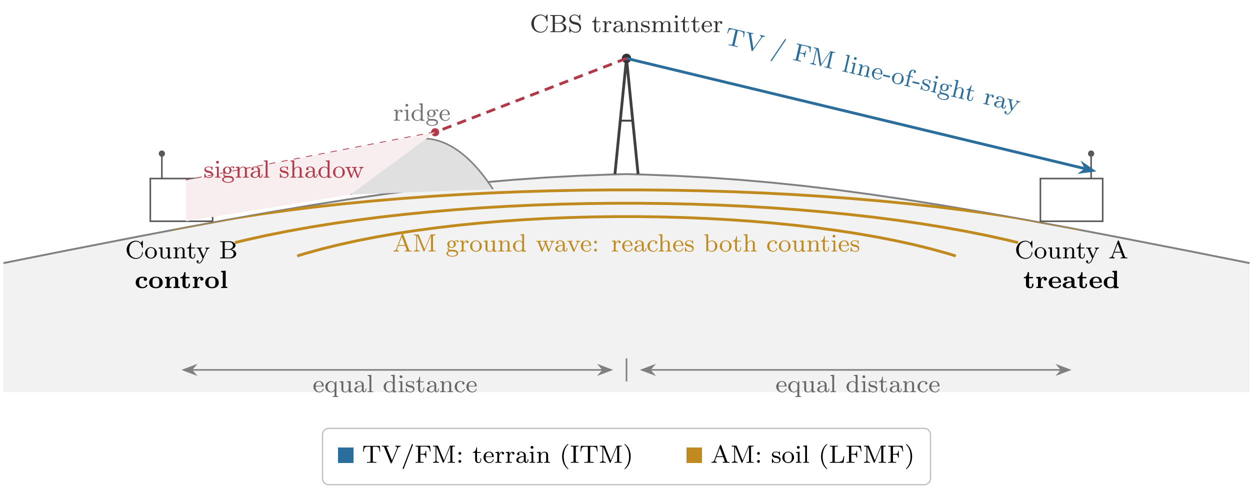

Figure 3: TV/FM terrain identification. Holding distance fixed, terrain can block line-of-sight TV/FM reception in one county but not another. AM ground waves diffract around terrain, so AM is identified through soil conductivity.

Terrain-driven variation is plausibly exogenous to 1970s political preferences because topography is fixed across geological timescales. The design does not require tower placement itself to be exogenous. Tower parameters—location, power, height, and frequency—reflect broadcaster choices, but the topographic map that determines signal propagation is fixed. TV and FM radio infrastructure was also built in the 1950s and 1960s, before the ERA became politically salient, and tower placement followed commercial logic such as population density and real-estate costs rather than ideological targeting.

AM exposure raises a different concern because raw soil conductivity may be endogenous to economic geography. I therefore instrument AM signal strength with a path-integrated geochemical IV. I sample SiO_2 concentration, an inert structural compound, along each propagation corridor and feed it through the LFMF engine. The term $\bar{\sigma}$ denotes the average soil-conductivity benchmark. The residual $\text{IV} = \text{LFMF}(\sigma_{SiO_2}) - \text{LFMF}(\bar{\sigma})$ subtracts the LFMF prediction under average conductivity from the prediction under SiO_2-implied conductivity along the same transmitter-receiver path. This residual captures variation in predicted AM signal strength generated by path-specific geology, holding tower locations and other propagation inputs fixed. [17] Figure 16 shows the spatial variation in ground conductivity, SiO_2 concentration, and the residualized instrument. First-stage F-statistics well exceed the modern benchmark of 104.7 across most specifications (Lee et al. 2022). Figure 4 summarizes the AM identification strategy.

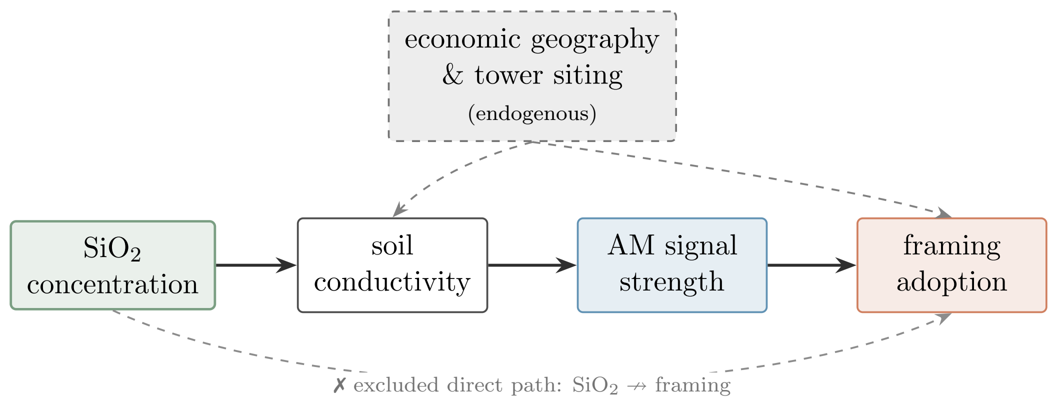

Figure 4: AM identification. SiO_2 instruments AM signal strength through soil conductivity. Dashed paths show why raw conductivity is endogenous; the ruled-out path is a direct effect of SiO_2 on framing adoption.

I address the third concern with pre-treatment controls. To measure pre-existing conservative networks, I digitized JBS membership lists from 1964–74 and geocoded members verified as paying dues before January 1972. I create a binary indicator for whether any JBS member resided in a county or district during the pre-treatment period.[18] These lists are incomplete because members often formally resigned from membership rolls due to social stigma while maintaining informal ties (Dallek 2023). I also control for religious environments receptive to Schlafly's message independent of CBS exposure, using 1971 Association of Religion Data Archives (ARDA) church membership data to calculate county-level shares evangelical Protestant, mainline Protestant, and Catholic. These controls address the con-

[17] The AM signal skin depth is about 8–18 m, meaning the signal interacts with deep subsoil and bedrock well below the agricultural plow layer (< 0.8 m). Surface SiO_2 acts as a geological tag for this deep mineralogy because the topsoil and underlying saprolite weathered from the same parent material.

[18] This collection was recovered from a dumpster after the JBS moved headquarters from Massachusetts to Wisconsin in 1989. The membership records I use as controls were stored as an office list and a set of index cards containing dues-paid information, names, and addresses. The 1964–74 membership lists likely capture VIP members rather than a comprehensive membership roll. The comprehensive 1989 JBS membership list, compiled after Schlafly's campaign, is the focus of a separate paper, *A Republic, Not a Democracy: The Legacy of John Birch Society Membership.*

cern that CBS exposure is proxying for Schlafly's pre-existing network or local religious demand, rather than broadcast access.

In the ANES public-opinion analysis, the main specifications use CBS TV, CBS FM, and CBS AM exposure. Broader ANES placebo outcomes assess whether the estimates reflect a general conservative-media shift rather than an ERA-specific response. In the Illinois legislative-behavior specifications, I add exposure to ABC, NBC, and PBS to distinguish CBS-specific effects from general television availability. Similar patterns across all networks would point to general broadcast exposure; CBS-specific effects would instead indicate that Schlafly's regular appearances created a distinct channel of influence.

FM/AM overlap raises one measurement issue. I separately measure CBS TV and CBS FM exposure, but the CBS FM measure may also capture CBS AM radio exposure: "the first AM-FM factory installed car radios appeared in 1963 and 1964" (Schulenberg and Shuler 2015), and many CBS FM affiliates also broadcast on AM. Because FM and AM are highly collinear, I do not estimate them jointly. I instead estimate CBS AM in parallel specifications that replace FM. The geochemical IV for AM uses soil-mineralogy variation independent of the topographic variation identifying FM, so the parallel specifications draw on distinct sources of exogenous broadcast exposure.

Spillovers present a final measurement concern. If Schlafly shifted national discourse, control counties also received some treatment, violating the Stable Unit Treatment Value Assumption (SUTVA). My estimates therefore capture the marginal effect of local CBS exposure beyond the national baseline shift. Schlafly's PSR distribution network also crossed county boundaries. If treated counties affected control counties, standard errors would be understated and treatment effects diluted toward zero. I partially address this issue through state $\times$ year fixed effects and JBS membership controls, but cannot fully rule out spillovers. Estimates should be interpreted as the effect of differential CBS exposure intensity, not the effect of Schlafly's campaign versus no campaign.

Both the ANES public-opinion and Illinois legislative-behavior studies estimate reduced-form, intent-to-treat effects based on predicted signal strength, not actual viewing or listening. Not everyone in a CBS-covered county watched *CBS Morning News*, listened to *Spectrum*, or encountered Schlafly's commentaries directly. I therefore estimate the effect of CBS availability on attitudes toward women's rights, attitudes toward the women's liberation movement, Illinois legislative votes, and legislators' rhetoric. These effects operate through both direct exposure and indirect channels, including local discussion, constituent pressure, newspaper coverage, and Schlafly's increased visibility.[19]

3 Legislative Behavior in Illinois

I begin with Illinois because it provides the paper's most direct empirical test. The outcome is the institutional decision that determined ratification, and the archive records both how legislators voted and how they spoke about the ERA. I therefore ask whether

[19] I do not decompose listening or viewing probability from the effect conditional on exposure, separate direct media exposure from indirect effects, or isolate amplification effects such as CBS increasing readership of the *Phyllis Schlafly Report*.

Schlafly's CBS platform changed ERA roll-call votes and legislative rhetoric using digitized debates and votes from the Illinois General Assembly.

3.1 Data

Among the five pivotal states, Illinois is uniquely suited to a legislative analysis. Article IV of the 1970 Illinois Constitution mandated transcription of General Assembly sessions. Missouri has no legal requirement to record debates, while North Carolina, Florida, and Oklahoma preserve their debates in archival audio recordings that remain undigitized. Illinois is therefore the only pivotal state where I can measure both ERA votes and the language legislators used during ERA debates.[20]

I digitized ERA debate transcripts from the Illinois General Assembly for 1972–1980, covering eight sessions, and compiled legislator votes from Newspapers.com records from the *Chicago Tribune* and other newspapers.[21] I focus on the House because the Senate debates had too few speakers for sufficient statistical power.

For legislators who spoke during these debates, I measure behavior with two outcomes: their ERA ratification vote (binary: 0 = no, 1 = yes) and the semantic similarity between their speech and Schlafly's newsletters published before the debate (continuous: 0 to 1).

I digitized the Illinois legislative district maps into GIS shapefiles.[22] The legislative analysis requires one additional exposure step because Illinois legislative districts do not always align with county boundaries. To assign exposure to districts, I calculate each county's land-area share within each district, then aggregate exposure separately for TV and FM as:

$$TV_{dnt} = \sum_{c=1}^{C_d} w_{cd} \cdot 1_{cn}(\text{TV}) \quad \text{and} \quad FM_{dnt} = \sum_{c=1}^{C_d} w_{cd} \cdot 1_{cn}(\text{FM})$$

where w_{cd} is county c's share of district d's land area, $1_{cn}(\text{TV})$ is the binary indicator for county c receiving network n's TV signal at -55 dBm, and $1_{cn}(\text{FM})$ is the indicator for receiving network n's FM signal at -47 dBm. Each aggregation produces a continuous treatment variable ranging from 0 (no coverage) to 1 (full coverage) for each district. Figures 14 and 15 show TV and FM coverage variation in Illinois by county and legislative district, respectively.

In Figure 14, 67 of 102 Illinois counties had CBS TV coverage, while only 9 of 102 counties had CBS FM coverage, based on towers as of March 1972 for television and November 1971 for radio. Figure 15 aggregates this variation to the 78th Illinois General Assembly district map. At the district level, 57 of 59 legislative districts had CBS TV coverage exceeding 25% of their land area at the -55 dBm threshold, while only 34 of 59 districts had CBS FM coverage exceeding 25% at the -47 dBm threshold. The substantially greater variation in

[20] Schlafly lived in Alton, Illinois, and ran for U.S. Congress twice (1952, 1970) in Illinois.

[21] The other Illinois newspapers are the Daily Calumet, Daily Chronicle, Daily Herald, Decatur Daily, Dispatch, Dixon, Edwardsville Intelligencer, Herald, Herald & Review, Pantagraph, Southern Illinoisan, and News Journal.

[22] Starting in the 78th General Assembly, both chambers used the same legislative map, whereas prior, district maps were distinct.

CBS FM coverage across counties and districts provides the primary identifying variation for the Illinois vote analysis.

For CBS AM, I use the same area-weighted aggregation, replacing the binary exposure indicator with continuous LFMF signal strength (and its SiO_2 IV):

$$AM_{dt} = \sum_{c=1}^{C_d} w_{cd} \cdot S_c(\text{AM})$$

where $S_c(\text{AM})$ is the continuous signal strength at county c's centroid. I estimate AM in parallel specifications that replace FM (Panels B and C of Tables 12–14).

Beyond the controls described in Section 2, I digitized three Illinois-specific covariates. First, I control for pre-existing conservative ideology using official Illinois vote records from 1964, which report county-level returns and ward, suburb, and township breakdowns for Cook County. I calculate Goldwater's vote share in both the Republican primary and general election, then aggregate each measure to the district level using county land-area weights. Second, I control for pre-existing ERA sentiment using official Illinois vote records from 1970. Districts that voted against the 1970 Illinois Constitution may have harbored latent opposition to equal-rights language. Third, I control for legislator characteristics by digitizing biographies from Illinois Blue Books, which provide party, professional (insurance) affiliation, veteran status, religious affiliation, and gender. Table 11 reports descriptive statistics for the variables in the Illinois General Assembly study.

To measure Schlafly's rhetorical influence, I digitized all 81 *Phyllis Schlafly Report* (PSR) newsletters on the ERA from 1972–1980.[23] For the main analysis, I use the 21 of these 81 newsletters curated on the Eagle Forum website.[24] I transform the two text corpora–legislative debates and PSR newsletters–into similarity scores. The Appendix provides additional detail on the similarity measure and tests the correlation between semantic similarity and ERA votes. Figure 5 summarizes how I measure rhetorical adoption.

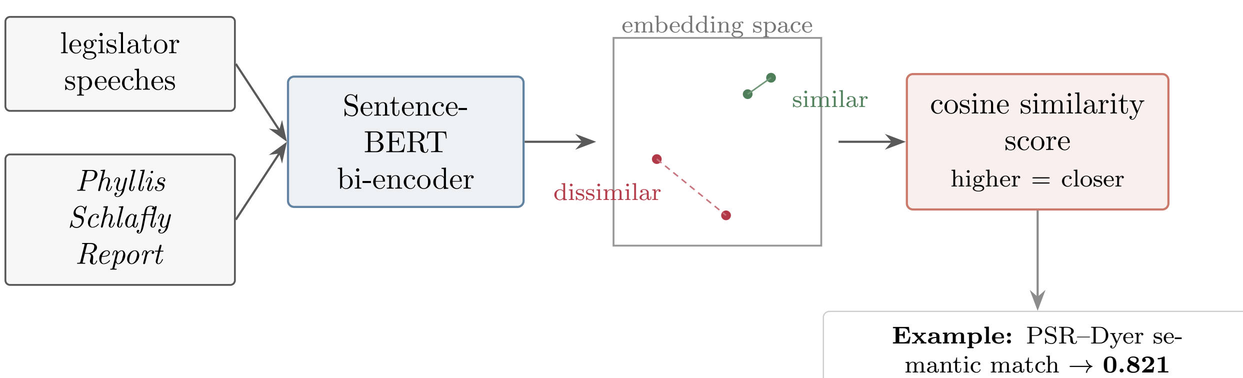

Figure 5: Measuring rhetorical adoption. Sentence-BERT embeds legislator speeches and PSR newsletters; cosine similarity measures semantic proximity. The example shows high similarity without requiring verbatim overlap.

[23]This digitized PSR text corpus totals 291,180 words.

[24]For robustness, I digitized the remaining 60 newsletters from the comprehensive *Legacy Collection 1967–2016* purchased in DVD format from the Phyllis Schlafly Eagles website.

3.2 Cross-Sectional Specification

I estimate the effect of CBS exposure on Illinois legislative behavior with continuous district-level treatment measures for TV and FM radio. The measures account for county-level variation in predicted signal coverage within legislative districts. The specification is:

$$y_{dt} = \chi_{TV} \cdot \text{CBS TV}_{dt} + \chi_{FM} \cdot \text{CBS FM}_{dt} + \beta \cdot X_{dt} + \rho_t + \epsilon_{dt}$$

where y_{dt} is either legislator d's ERA vote in session t (0 = no, 1 = yes) or the semantic similarity between the legislator's speech and the most recently published PSR newsletters (continuous: 0 to 1).

The treatment variables CBS TV_{dt} and CBS FM_{dt} are district-weighted CBS signal exposures for television and FM radio, respectively. A value of 1 means the district lies entirely within CBS TV or FM coverage; a value of 0 means the district has no predicted coverage; intermediate values reflect partial geographic exposure. I include the TV and FM measures simultaneously, along with analogous measures for ABC TV, NBC TV, and PBS TV, to separate television from radio exposure and to isolate the CBS-specific effect from general media exposure.

The coefficient χ_{FM} measures the effect of moving from zero CBS FM coverage to full CBS FM coverage, holding CBS TV coverage constant. The coefficient χ_{TV} measures the analogous effect for CBS TV, holding CBS FM constant. For vote outcomes, negative coefficients indicate that CBS exposure reduced ERA support. For similarity outcomes, positive coefficients indicate greater adoption of Schlafly's framing.

I estimate AM radio in parallel specifications because CBS FM and AM are collinear. Panels B and C replace FM with continuous z-scored AM signal strength while holding the TV network controls fixed. Panel B reports AM by OLS; Panel C instruments with the SiO_2 geochemical IV.

Legislative session fixed effects, ρ_t, control for time-varying factors common to all legislators in a session. Legislator and district-level controls, X_{dt}, include JBS membership, 1971 religious composition, Goldwater vote share, 1970 Illinois Constitution vote share, and legislator characteristics. Standard errors are clustered at the legislative district level because legislators from the same district share CBS exposure and similar constituent pressures.

The specification is cross-sectional because Schlafly began attacking the ERA in the PSR before the Illinois General Assembly began debating federal ERA ratification, leaving no clean pre-period for legislative debate or voting outcomes.

3.3 Identification Threats

Illinois presents challenges in addition to the threats discussed in Section 2. The first concern is that Illinois ranks as the second flattest state by area. Much of the state is prairie and glacial plain, but the natural borders created by the Mississippi, Ohio, and Wabash river valleys still create meaningful signal variation.[25] For both the ANES and Illinois samples, exposure is coded as the best reachable CBS signal from any station within the distance

[25] A district in western Illinois near the Mississippi bluffs receives different signal strength than one 50 miles east on the flat prairie, despite similar latitudes.

cutoff, including out-of-state stations. Cook County presents a particular challenge: it contains half of Illinois's legislative districts but is uniformly flat. In urban areas, buildings can obstruct signals similarly to terrain, but I lack historical building elevation maps for 1970s Chicago to input into the ITM. The county-level aggregation also means districts within Cook County will not have variation in the religious composition control, which is why additional Illinois-specific controls are included.

The second concern is selection into speaking during ERA debates. If CBS exposure affects who speaks, then exposure can create selection bias. The direction is unclear: CBS exposure might make anti-ERA legislators more vocal, overstating effects, or cause some legislators to stay silent, understating effects. Selection would need to correlate with topographical signal variation conditional on controls, which seems unlikely. The main question is not whether CBS exposure changed the private views of legislators who never spoke, but whether it changed the behavior of legislators who shaped the debate and vote. In Table 13, I replace the outcome variable with whether a legislator spoke, yielding null results for all three major commercial TV networks as well as CBS FM. The AM OLS estimate is significant in the full specification, but the IV estimate is null, suggesting the OLS result reflects endogenous correlates of soil conductivity rather than a causal effect. Exposure to non-commercial PBS did cause legislators to speak more, but the null results for the other networks are consistent with no selection into the set of legislators who spoke on the ERA.[26]

The last concern, specific to the similarity outcome, is reverse causality. Could legislators' speeches influence Schlafly's newsletters, creating a feedback loop where similarity reflects her responding to them rather than vice versa? I address this potential reverse causality in three ways. First, I measure similarity to all PSR before session t, capturing the available ideological supply to legislators at the time they spoke. Second, Schlafly began publishing anti-ERA content in February 1972, before most state legislators had taken public positions on the ERA. She was more likely to influence them than they were to influence her. Third, the design permits a robustness check that excludes newsletters in which Schlafly responds to or praises specific state legislators.

3.4 Results

Table 12 reports cross-sectional estimates for the ERA votes of Illinois legislators, who spoke on the ERA. The columns add controls progressively: column (1) is the baseline specification, column (2) adds legislator controls and legislative session fixed effects, column (3) adds district controls and legislative session fixed effects, and column (4) reports the full specification.

The main voting result is a negative CBS FM effect. Once district-level controls are included, CBS FM exposure consistently reduces ERA support in specifications (3) and (4). In the full specification, moving from no CBS FM coverage to full coverage reduces the probability of voting "yes" by 39.7 pp. CBS TV, by contrast, shows a null effect of -14.1 pp. The divergence points to FM radio, which reached constituents in cars, as the broadcast channel most closely connected to ERA votes.

[26] Table 16 shows that women, veterans, Protestant legislators, and legislators in districts with more support for the 1970 Illinois Constitution were more likely to speak on the ERA.

The other-network results help separate Schlafly's CBS content from general media exposure. NBC shows a significant positive effect of 68.6 pp, while PBS and ABC coefficients are insignificant. In the full specification, CBS FM is the only network with a consistently negative and significant effect. Panels B and C of Table 12 report the AM results; both the OLS and IV estimates are insignificant in the full joint specification with TV, consistent with the FM-specific vote effect.

Table 16 reports the full-control specification. Republican party affiliation (−34.4 pp) and veteran status (−19.9 pp) are both associated with significantly lower ERA support. Legislators' affiliation with the insurance industry has a positive but insignificant coefficient (6.9 pp), providing suggestive evidence against the insurance-lobby hypothesis.

Table 14 turns from votes to rhetoric, reporting cross-sectional estimates for semantic similarity between legislators' speeches and Schlafly's newsletters. CBS TV exposure significantly increases similarity across all four specifications. In the full specification, moving from no CBS TV coverage to full coverage increases similarity by 17.1 pp. CBS FM shows a significant negative effect of −5.7 pp on similarity, opposite in direction to its voting effect.

The AM results point to the same framing channel. In Panel C of Table 14, the AM IV is positive and significant across all four specifications, reaching 16.8 pp in the full specification with a first-stage F of 235.3. The CBS TV coefficient remains large and significant alongside it at 19.6 pp, indicating that both broadcast channels independently transmitted Schlafly's rhetorical framework. The OLS AM estimate in Panel B is negative and insignificant, while the IV estimate is positive and significant, consistent with geographic endogeneity in soil conductivity. The IV isolates variation in AM exposure induced by soil chemistry and suggests that AM content exposure increased framing adoption.

Taken together, the vote and similarity results suggest that CBS channels operated through different mechanisms. CBS TV, which presented Schlafly's arguments visually, supplied framing and vocabulary that legislators could adopt in floor debate. CBS FM radio, by contrast, appears to have shifted constituent attitudes and thereby changed votes without necessarily changing how legislators spoke. PBS also shows a significant positive similarity effect, consistent with Schlafly's guest appearances and reruns on PBS, such as William Buckley's *Firing Line* (1973) and *Woman* (1974). ABC shows a significant and consistently negative similarity effect across the four specifications, with a final effect of −20.0 pp. NBC is also negative but not consistently significant across specifications, in contrast to its positive voting effect.

The smaller standard errors in the similarity analysis reflect the larger number of text pairs. For each legislative session at time t, each legislator's speech is compared to all past PSR issues available before t, so later sessions generate more similarity comparisons. At the legislator level, Table 16 shows that Jewish legislators and Republicans were significantly more likely to talk like the PSR.

To interpret magnitudes, Table 15 standardizes the effects in two ways: as a one standard deviation increase in CBS coverage within a legislative district and as a change from the 10$^{\text{th}}$ to the 90$^{\text{th}}$ percentile of CBS coverage. The CBS FM vote effect corresponds to an 18.4 pp decline for a one standard deviation increase in CBS FM coverage, or a 39.7 pp decline when moving from the 10$^{\text{th}}$ to the 90$^{\text{th}}$ percentile (0% → 100%). The full-range gap and raw coefficient coincide because CBS FM spans the complete 0–100% range.

For CBS TV's effect on similarity to the PSR in the TV+FM specification, the 17.1 pp raw coefficient corresponds to a 4.4 pp increase per standard deviation, or 10.6 pp when moving from the 10^{th} to the 90^{th} percentile of CBS TV coverage. In the TV+AM IV specification, the CBS TV coefficient increases to 19.6 pp, corresponding to 5.0 pp per standard deviation or 12.2 pp across the 10^{th}–90^{th} percentile gap. For the AM IV, the 16.8 pp raw coefficient corresponds to 5.3 pp per standard deviation or 12.1 pp across the same percentile gap.

Table 17 tests whether the Illinois results depend on the signal threshold. For ERA votes, CBS FM is negative and significant across all three tiers—−39.7 pp at strong, −28.8 pp at medium, and −19.9 pp at weak. The attenuation is consistent with increasing measurement error at lower thresholds, where signal reception becomes less reliable. CBS TV shows no significant voting effect at the strong threshold but becomes unstable at medium and weak thresholds, where its coverage variation collapses. For similarity to the PSR, CBS TV is positive and significant at both strong (18.3 pp) and medium (27.0 pp) thresholds, while CBS FM's negative similarity effect is stable across all three tiers. The robustness of CBS FM for voting and CBS TV for similarity across the strong and medium thresholds confirms that the baseline channel-specific pattern is not an artifact of the particular threshold chosen. The AM IV effect on similarity is likewise robust at both the strong and medium TV thresholds. The variation across columns reflects changes in the TV control variable, since AM itself is continuous and does not change definition across tiers.

To translate the CBS FM voting estimate into a count of potentially pivotal votes, I calculate each "no" voter i's flip probability in each session, capped at 1.0:

$$\text{Flip Probability}_i = |\hat{\beta}^{\text{CBS FM}}| \times \text{CBS FM}_i$$

and then sum these individual flip probabilities across all "no" voters. Table 18 shows that, among speaking legislators, 34 "no" votes could have been "yes" votes without Schlafly's influence, with a 99% confidence interval of $[10, 58]$. The cumulative margin was only 66 votes across all sessions, and the Illinois General Assembly imposed a three-fifths supermajority threshold. The point estimate of 34 flipped votes—more than half the cumulative margin—could therefore have been decisive in several individual sessions, even before accounting for peer-pressure effects from additional yes votes.

Within Illinois, CBS—the network that gave Schlafly a weekly platform—is the only network producing consistent effects, though the operative channel differs by outcome. CBS radio (FM) drives the voting effect, reducing ERA support by 39.7 pp. CBS television drives the framing effect, increasing legislators' semantic similarity to Schlafly's newsletters by 17.1 pp. A geochemical IV for CBS AM confirms the framing channel through independent variation, increasing similarity by 16.8 pp. FM's concentrated, high-fidelity coverage created repeated exposure on daily commutes sufficient to shift the political environment legislators faced. AM's broad but lower-fidelity coverage produced diffuse exposure sufficient to transmit Schlafly's vocabulary and rhetorical framework but not the sustained pressure that changes votes. Television, received at fixed household locations, gave legislators the specific framing they adopted on the floor.

The Illinois evidence shows that exposure to Schlafly on CBS shifted legislative behavior, affecting not only how legislators voted but also how they talked about the ERA. Legislators in CBS TV-covered districts adopted Schlafly's framing, vocabulary, argumentative structure, and issue bundling, while legislators in CBS FM-covered districts changed how they voted. The patterns remain after controlling for legislators' characteristics and their districts' pre-existing networks, spatial preferences, and religious composition. The results suggest that the effects are not driven by general media consumption but by the specific content and reach of Schlafly's CBS platform.

Illinois establishes the paper's strongest empirical claim. The next section asks whether the same broadcast channel is visible in mass public opinion across the five pivotal states.

4 Public Opinion from Five Pivotal States

Having shown that CBS exposure changed ERA voting and rhetoric inside the Illinois legislature, I next ask whether the same broadcast channel is visible in mass opinion across the five pivotal states. This analysis is corroborating rather than the paper's primary causal test: the ANES provides the best available public-opinion evidence, but its state- and county-level samples are thin and its pre-treatment survey waves limit conventional pre-trend assessment. Within that constraint, the question is whether counties with greater post-1974 access to Schlafly's CBS platform moved differently on the attitudes her campaign targeted.

4.1 Data

I use two primary outcomes from the ANES Time Series. The first is the feeling thermometer toward the women's liberation movement (VCF0225), which rates the group from 0 (cold) to 100 (warm), with 50 neutral.[27] Schlafly explicitly linked the ERA to the women's liberation movement, characterizing pro-ERA supporters as radicals who "hate men, marriage, and children" in her November 1972 PSR. Sentiment toward the movement therefore captures the cultural cleavage she sought to widen.

The second outcome is the equal-role scale (VCF0834), a seven-point item running from "women and men should have an equal role" (1) to "a woman's place is in the home" (7).[28] This measure captures attitudes toward the concrete domain Schlafly targeted: whether women should participate equally in running business, industry, and government. The equal-role scale is therefore distinct from sentiment toward the women's movement as a group.

I rescale both outcomes to the unit interval before estimation. I divide the thermometer by 100 and map the equal-role scale as $\tilde{y} = \frac{(7-y)}{6}$ so that higher values denote more egalitarian sentiment.[29] I then standardize each rescaled outcome to mean zero and unit variance, so the coefficients reported below are in standard deviations of the outcome. The scaling makes estimates across the two ANES outcomes comparable.

[27] The item is top-coded such that 97–100 collapse into 97. I drop "don't know" (98) and non-response (99). The thermometer carried the "women's liberation movement" wording in 1970, 1972, 1974, 1976, 1980, and 1984; it was not fielded in 1978 or 1982 within this window. I do not use the feminist thermometer (VCF0253) because it first appears in 1988. The ERA-support question (VCF0833) is the most direct measure of stated approval, but it appears only after Schlafly's CBS platform was already in place—in 1976, 1978, and 1980—so I use it only descriptively. See the discussion of Table 10 in Section 4.4.

[28] I drop NA (0) and "don't know, or haven't thought much about it" (8).

[29] I do not collapse the thermometer into an above/below-50 indicator, and I retain every interior scale point.

The analytic sample consists of ANES respondents observed at the county level in the five pivotal states over six survey waves. The sample has an important limitation: the ANES was designed for national-level inference rather than state- or county-level analysis, so statistical power is low, especially for individual-state estimates. I therefore pool observations across the pivotal states by year and include state $\times$ year fixed effects. State-by-year fixed effects absorb state-specific trends and national time trends, so identification comes from differential changes in CBS-exposed and unexposed counties within the same state over time.

For each county, I construct the CBS TV, FM, and AM exposure measures exactly as described in Section 2: a binary TV indicator at the -55 dBm VHF threshold (47 CFR §73.683), a binary FM indicator at the -47 dBm city-grade threshold (47 CFR §73.315), and a continuous, z-scored AM measure from the LFMF ground-wave engine instrumented with the SiO_2 geochemical IV. Beyond the controls in Section 2, I add respondent gender and religion from the ANES.

Tables 2 and 3 report descriptive statistics and balance between counties exposed and unexposed to CBS FM. CBS-FM-exposed counties are significantly more likely to have JBS members and a higher Catholic share, and significantly fewer Evangelicals and Mainline Protestants, than unexposed counties. Respondents in exposed counties are also more likely to be Catholic or Jewish and less likely to be Evangelical. The imbalances motivate the county- and respondent-level controls used below.

4.2 Difference-in-Differences Specification

I estimate the effect of CBS TV and FM radio exposure on public opinion with a difference-in-differences design. The comparison is between counties with and without predicted CBS signal coverage, before and after Schlafly obtained a regular CBS platform. The post period begins in 1974: the first ANES survey wave after Schlafly began her regular CBS radio commentaries in 1973 and the year her CBS television appearances began. The main specification is:

$$\begin{aligned} y_{ict} = \gamma_{TV} \cdot D_c^{TV} \cdot Post_t + \gamma_{FM} \cdot D_c^{FM} \cdot Post_t \\ + \delta_{TV} \cdot D_c^{TV} + \delta_{FM} \cdot D_c^{FM} + X_c'\beta + W_i'\lambda + \alpha_{s(c),t} + \varepsilon_{ict}. \end{aligned}$$

where $D_c^{TV} = 1_c^{CBS}(\text{TV})$, $D_c^{FM} = 1_c^{CBS}(\text{FM})$, and $Post_t = 1(t \geq 1974)$. The vectors X_c and W_i denote county-level and respondent-level controls, respectively, and $\alpha_{s(c),t}$ denotes state-by-year fixed effects.

The treatment variables are the interactions between baseline CBS exposure and the post-Schlafly period, $D_c^{TV} \cdot Post_t$ and $D_c^{FM} \cdot Post_t$. The uninteracted exposure indicators, D_c^{TV} and D_c^{FM}, absorb baseline level differences between counties with and without CBS coverage. The exposure indicators equal one if county c receives CBS TV signal strength of at least -55 dBm or CBS FM signal strength of at least -47 dBm, respectively. The coefficients γ_{TV} and γ_{FM} capture differential changes in sentiment in CBS TV- and CBS FM-covered counties after Schlafly's CBS platform was in place, relative to otherwise comparable counties without the corresponding coverage. Estimating both measures in the same specification separates television, received primarily at home, from FM radio, received more plausibly in cars.

For AM radio, I estimate parallel specifications that replace CBS FM exposure with a continuous, z-scored measure of CBS AM signal strength while retaining the CBS TV measure (Panels B and C of Tables 4 and 5). Many CBS FM affiliates simulcast on AM, so the FM and AM measures are highly collinear and cannot be estimated jointly. Panel B estimates the AM specification by OLS. Panel C instruments the post-1974 AM exposure interaction with the corresponding $SiO_2 \times Post_t$ interaction, controlling for baseline AM signal strength and baseline SiO_2. The parallel specifications test whether AM radio—which reached both home and car listeners but with lower fidelity than FM—independently shifted sentiment.

State-by-year fixed effects, $\alpha_{s(c),t}$, absorb shocks common to all counties in the same state and survey year, including national changes flexibly interacted with state-specific conditions. County-level controls, X_c, include JBS membership and religious composition. Respondent-level controls, W_i, include religion indicators and respondent gender. Standard errors are clustered at the county level to account for within-county correlation in individual responses over time. Because treatment operates at the county level but outcomes are measured at the individual level, the treatment coefficients are intent-to-treat effects across individuals in treated counties, including non-viewers.

The key identifying assumption is parallel trends: absent Schlafly's CBS appearances, counties with and without CBS coverage within the same state would have experienced similar changes in sentiment toward women's rights and the women's movement. This is the main limitation of the ANES design. Question availability leaves only one or two pre-treatment waves for the difference-in-differences outcomes, so the survey data cannot provide the kind of pre-trend discipline one would want for a standalone causal claim.[30] For this reason, I interpret the five-state ANES results as corroborating evidence. The credibility of the design rests more on the plausibility of terrain-driven TV/FM variation and geology-driven AM variation than on a conventional pre-trends test.

The design is most credible where terrain creates signal variation that is plausibly unrelated to changes in ERA attitudes.[31] Missouri, North Carolina, and Oklahoma have substantial elevation changes, river valleys, and forested regions that obstruct broadcast signals. Florida and Illinois are the two flattest states in the United States, which makes identification more challenging. The states with more diverse terrain therefore provide the strongest identifying variation, while the flatter states contribute additional observations.

4.3 Results

Tables 4 and 5 report the difference-in-differences estimates for sentiment toward women's rights and the women's (liberation) movement across the five pivotal states. The columns add controls progressively: column (1) is the baseline specification, column (2) adds respondent controls and state × year fixed effects, column (3) adds county controls and state × year fixed effects, and column (4) reports the full specification.

Table 4 shows the main public-opinion result. CBS FM exposure after 1974 reduced

[30] Table 10 reports the survey years available for each ANES outcome of primary interest. The pre-treatment support for parallel trends is therefore outcome-specific rather than uniform across all measures.

[31] For example, two rural Missouri counties with similar religious composition and JBS presence may differ in CBS exposure because one lies in the Ozark highlands while another sits in a river valley. Similarly, two rural Illinois counties with similar Goldwater vote shares, religious composition, and JBS presence may differ because one sits in a river-valley basin while another has clear line-of-sight to the St. Louis transmitter.

sentiment toward women's rights by 0.21 standard deviations in the full specification. The estimate is negative in all specifications and significant in columns (2)–(4), after state × year fixed effects absorb state-level trends. CBS TV is null in all three specifications with state × year fixed effects, likely because CBS TV coverage reaches 90.5% of the sample (Table 2), leaving limited identifying variation. For sentiment toward the women's (liberation) movement in Table 5, neither CBS FM nor CBS TV produces a significant effect in the full specification. Panels B and C of Tables 4 and 5 report the AM results for both outcomes; the OLS and IV AM estimates are also insignificant in the full specifications.

The contrast between the two outcomes is substantively informative. The women's-rights outcome asks whether women should have an equal role in running business, industry, and government, which is the concrete domain Schlafly targeted. Her framing cast the ERA as a threat to specific privileges rather than as a dispute over abstract equality. CBS FM reduced support for women's equal role in society without reducing warmth toward the women's movement itself, a pattern consistent with Schlafly's strategy of separating the "professional women" she claimed to support from the "women liberationists" she attacked.

Table 6 reports the control estimates from the full specification. Respondent gender is significant for women's rights (−0.112 SD), indicating that female respondents reported lower support for women's equal role than male respondents. Relative to the non-religious reference category, Evangelical (−0.540 SD), Catholic (−0.365 SD), and Mainline Protestant (−0.330 SD) respondents all showed substantially lower women's-rights sentiment. At the county level, a higher Evangelical population share reduced women's-rights sentiment, while a higher Catholic population share increased it. Having a JBS member in the county had no significant effect on women's-rights sentiment (−0.085 SD), but reduced sentiment toward the women's movement by 0.263 SD.

Table 7 tests whether the ANES results depend on the signal threshold used to define CBS exposure. The table considers three tiers: strong (−55 dBm TV, −47 dBm FM), medium (−63 dBm TV, −57 dBm FM), and weak (−75 dBm TV, −77 dBm FM), corresponding to progressively lower FCC reception contours. Coefficients differ slightly from Table 4 because the sensitivity analysis estimates each network channel in a separate regression rather than simultaneously. For women's rights, the CBS FM effect is negative and significant at both the strong (−0.172 SD) and medium (−0.192 SD) thresholds but vanishes at the weak threshold, where nearly all counties receive some signal and the identifying variation collapses. CBS TV cannot be tested at lower thresholds because coverage exceeds 94% of the sample at all tiers.

The stability of the CBS FM result across the strong and medium tiers, where identifying variation is cleanest, supports the baseline specification. In the sensitivity analysis, which estimates each channel individually rather than simultaneously, the continuous CBS AM IV is negative and significant for women's rights and marginally significant for the women's movement. The fact that the AM IV reaches significance when estimated separately from FM but not in the joint TV+AM specification likely reflects collinearity between the two radio measures: FM's concentrated, high-fidelity variation absorbs the overlapping component of AM's broader but more diffuse signal when the two measures compete for shared variation in the joint estimation with TV.

4.4 Other ANES Outcomes and the Schlafly Effect's Scope

Two concerns remain: specificity and scope. CBS FM coverage might proxy for general conservative media exposure rather than Schlafly's specific content. The five pivotal states were also selected because ratification was contested, which raises the possibility that the ANES effect is a pivotal-state artifact. Tables 8 and 9 address these concerns by re-estimating the difference-in-differences specification and its cross-sectional analogue across eleven ANES outcomes and three nested samples.

A generic conservative-media explanation would predict broad movement across racial attitudes, ideological thermometers, affect toward political groups, and other conservative-coded outcomes. The estimates do not show that pattern. In the pivotal states, CBS FM $\times$ Post-1974 is negative and significant for the equal-role scale (-0.213), but null for aid to Black Americans and for sentiment toward the police, Black militants, civil-rights leaders, liberals, conservatives, and the military. The flat response across this battery of conservative- and liberal-coded outcomes is inconsistent with CBS FM proxying for a broad conservative shift. The outcome that moves most clearly is the one closest to Schlafly's central ERA message: women's proper role in business, industry, government, and public life.

The one non-women's-rights outcome that also moves is rights of the accused. I interpret this not as a failed placebo, but as a spillover outcome. In the February 1975 *Phyllis Schlafly Report* titled "How ERA Will Affect Our Local Police," Schlafly labeled the ERA as a threat to local policing and criminal justice. She warned that "certain destructive forces in our society" had long sought to "handcuff our local police" by elevating "the rights of criminals" above "the safety of the community." Those attacks, she argued, had mostly failed because "the average American knows that the policeman is our friend – not our enemy – and that the 'thin blue line' is what stands between us and all those vicious criminals who prowl the streets of our cities." In her telling, the ERA gave those same forces a new tool: instead of crying "police brutality" or demanding "civilian review boards," they could "merely cry 'end sex discrimination'" and ask the federal courts to mandate equality in police departments.

Schlafly made the link to physical standards explicit: "There is nothing in the Equal Rights Amendment that requires any minimum standards–all it requires is equality." The result, she claimed, would be that police forces "would be reduced to the physical abilities of the average woman" in the face of urban crime. The courts-and-crime frame maps closely onto the ANES rights-of-accused item (VCF0832).[32] Because racial-policy, racial-affect, police and military affect, and ideology thermometer outcomes do not move, the rights-of-accused effect looks more like a response to Schlafly's courts-and-crime frame than evidence of a generalized conservative shift.

The sample gradient further clarifies the TV/FM estimand. The equal-role effect is concentrated in the five pivotal states (-0.213), attenuates in the full set of unratified states (-0.120), and becomes smaller and insignificant in the lower-48 sample (-0.053). The gradient is consistent with the effect being strongest in the battleground states where ERA

[32] VCF0832 is a seven-point scale asking respondents to place themselves between protecting the legal rights of those accused of crimes (1) and stopping criminal activity even at the risk of reducing those rights (7). I drop "don't know/haven't thought much" (9) and non-response (0), reverse and rescale it to $[0, 1]$ so that higher values denote more protection for the accused, then standardize as with the other ANES outcomes. ANES fielded the rights-of-accused item in 1970, 1972, 1974, 1976, and 1978 within this window.

ratification remained politically live, rather than with a uniform nationwide opinion shift. By contrast, the rights-of-accused result persists across broader samples, consistent with a nationally portable crime-and-policing frame. Unlike equal-role attitudes, which were most politically consequential in the ratification battlegrounds, the claim that the ERA would weaken police standards, empower federal courts, and leave cities exposed to criminals did not depend on living in a pivotal state.

Table 9 also illustrates why the difference-in-differences design matters. The cross-sectional specification asks whether CBS-exposed counties differ from unexposed counties in levels. The difference-in-differences specification asks whether exposed counties changed differently after Schlafly's CBS platform began. The specifications answer different empirical questions. In the pivotal states, CBS-covered counties were, if anything, warmer toward the women's movement in raw levels, suggesting that strong CBS-signal counties were more urban and liberal at baseline. The cross-section alone would therefore obscure, and in some cases reverse, the post-1974 divergence captured by the main design.

Table 10 reports the raw ANES means by baseline CBS FM exposure status and survey year in the five pivotal states.[33] These comparisons are descriptive and should not be interpreted as causal estimates: they do not include state $\times$ year fixed effects, respondent controls, county controls, or the difference-in-differences structure. The table provides transparency by showing the underlying year-by-year means, state sample sizes, and observations dropped during outcome cleaning. Panel D reports the direct ANES ERA approval question as a descriptive check on the raw pattern in stated ERA support. ERA support is high in 1976 even in these pivotal states and then declines later, consistent with the paper's interpretation that ERA support was broad but fragile. The decline in ERA support appears to be a broad national shift in the meaning of the ERA; my estimates do not attribute that aggregate collapse to CBS exposure, but ask whether Schlafly's CBS platform generated additional local movement around that national shift.

Taken as corroborating evidence, the five-state ANES results align with the Illinois analysis. The same CBS FM channel that reduced ERA support among Illinois legislators is associated with a decline in egalitarian gender-role attitudes in the pivotal-state electorate, while the absence of broad movement across racial, ideological, and affective outcomes makes a generic conservative-media explanation less likely. Because the pre-treatment survey record is thin, this section does not carry the paper's primary causal claim on its own. Instead, it shows the public-opinion pattern one would expect if Schlafly's broadcasts changed the political environment around ratification. The next section turns from effects to mechanism: why Schlafly's arguments resonated and how older anti-ERA claims became newly effective.

[33] CBS FM exposure is defined using CBS FM radio towers and network affiliations from the 1972 *Broadcasting Yearbook*, updated as of November 15, 1971, and held fixed across survey waves. The analogous CBS TV measure uses the 1972–73 *Television Factbook*, updated as of March 30, 1972. The 1971–72 baseline broadcast geography measures the CBS network environment in place before Schlafly's regular CBS broadcasts could affect public opinion. Later rows therefore compare respondents by baseline CBS FM exposure, not necessarily contemporaneous station affiliation or reception.

5 Economic and Historical Mechanisms

5.1 Old Arguments, New Audience

Cultural entrepreneurs who sell normative visions of society need not originate the ideas they sell. Often, they repackage existing claims for a new constituency. Schlafly's anti-ERA campaign fit this pattern. The core claims she used in 1972—women in combat, loss of alimony and child support, disruption of Social Security, and repeal of sex-specific legal protections—had circulated for nearly three decades among liberal–labor opponents of the ERA. The historical puzzle is therefore not where these arguments came from, but why they became politically effective in conservative hands.

The women's movement had been split from the beginning over how to reconcile equality and motherhood. After ratification of the Nineteenth Amendment in 1920, the movement fractured into two main camps. The first was the Women's Bureau coalition—labor unions, the National Consumers League, the YWCA, the National Council of Jewish Women, the National Council of Catholic Women, the National Council of Negro Women, and others—middle-class reformers who had fought for protective labor laws such as maximum hours, minimum wages, and night-work bans for women. They saw the ERA as a direct threat to everything they had built. The second camp was Alice Paul's National Woman's Party (NWP), a small group of wealthy, highly educated professional women who introduced the ERA in 1923 and wanted formal legal equality. The NWP initially tried to compromise by exempting labor laws from the ERA, but the Women's Bureau coalition rejected the exemption as insufficient. The NWP eventually concluded that laws applying only to women did more harm than good.

Both camps were constrained by the belief that only women could care adequately for children. The Women's Bureau coalition used that premise to justify special legal treatment for women as mothers. The NWP used the same premise to defend professional equality, but it did not resolve the child-rearing question; many members remained unmarried or ran households with paid help. Neither side could articulate a fully coherent position that addressed both equality and motherhood (Harrison 1988).

By the early 1970s, the ERA coalition had changed. Early ERA supporters included professional women who sought to eliminate protective legislation, such as night-work laws, that restricted employment. Title VII of the 1964 Civil Rights Act and two landmark cases then weakened the practical importance of those protections. *Weeks v. Southern Bell Telephone & Telegraph Company* (1967, appealed and won by NOW in 1969) and *Rosenfeld v. Southern Pacific Company* (1968, appealed and won in 1971) successfully challenged state laws restricting the weight female employees could lift on the job. The courts held that such laws violated Title VII and could not be used to create male-only jobs under a Bona Fide Occupational Qualification (BFOQ). Once courts had largely dismantled protective legislation, many liberal and union ERA opponents who had fought to retain those protections began supporting the amendment by the late 1960s. Figure 6 summarizes the coalition reversal that made Schlafly's message politically legible in the 1970s.

The liberal anti-ERA argument template was formalized in 1943 by Douglas Maggs, Solicitor General of the Department of Labor, at the request of Women's Bureau director Mary Anderson. The Department warned that the ERA would cause women's induction

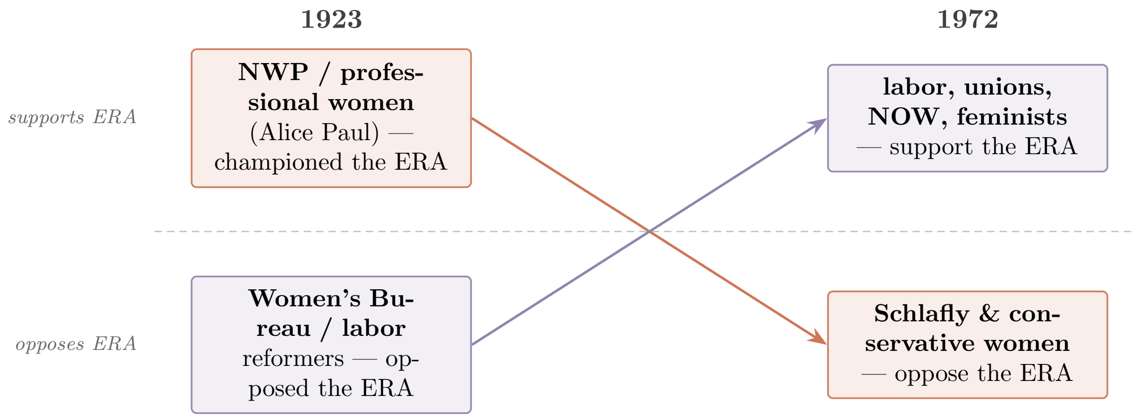

Figure 6: Position flip, 1923 vs. 1972. ERA support moved from NWP/professional women to labor, unions, NOW, and feminists; opposition moved from the Women's Bureau and labor reformers to Schlafly and conservative women.

into the military, changes in Social Security, upheaval in laws requiring husbands to support their families, and the repeal of protective labor legislation. The memo characterized ERA advocates as adherents of a "doctrinaire equality" that was "foreign to the spirit of Anglo-American legislation and jurisprudence." During the 1950 Senate debate over the ERA, Senator Estes Kefauver, a liberal Democrat from Tennessee, claimed that the ERA could "eliminate rape as a crime" and lead to "joint bathroom facilities."

Senator Carl Hayden, a Democrat from Arizona, then offered a rider, drafted with the Women's Bureau's guidance, providing that the ERA "shall not be construed to impair any rights, benefits, or exemptions conferred by law upon persons of the female sex." The maneuver let senators vote for both equal rights *and* special privileges. Alice Paul rejected the hybrid, and the ERA died. The same sequence repeated in 1953. The Hayden amendment, which promised equality and special treatment at the same time, effectively killed the ERA for the decade (Harrison 1988).

In February 1964, Emanuel Celler, a liberal Democratic congressman from New York who had introduced the Civil Rights Act in the House eight months earlier, opposed adding "sex" to Title VII with arguments identical to Schlafly's later claims: "Would male citizens be justified in insisting that women share with them the burdens of compulsory military service? What would become of traditional family relationships? What about alimony?" (Celler 1964).

The same arguments that appeared in Schlafly's first two anti-ERA newsletters in 1972 had been written almost thirty years earlier from within the liberal–labor establishment, not the conservative movement. Two decades after the Hayden rider, Schlafly did not say she opposed equal rights. Instead, she said she favored women's existing privileges—alimony, child support, and draft exemption—that the ERA would destroy. She let legislators feel they were protecting women by opposing the ERA, just as the Hayden rider had let senators feel they were supporting women by gutting it. Figure 7 summarizes the key point.

The Women's Bureau coalition had directed these arguments at labor unions and working-class women, warning that the ERA threatened workplace protections. Schlafly redirected them at homemakers and religious conservatives, warning that the ERA threatened domestic

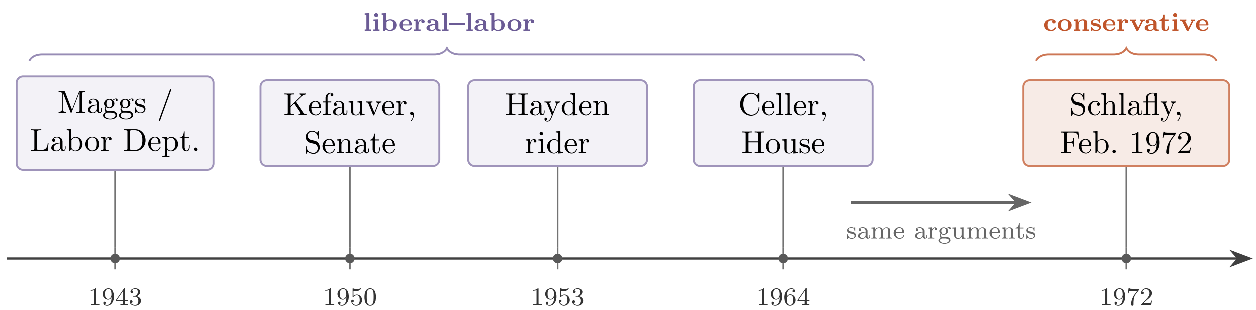

Figure 7: Old arguments, new audience. Schlafly repackaged claims previously used by liberal–labor ERA opponents; the innovation was the carrier and audience, not the menu of claims.

privileges. The logical structure was the same; the market was different. What changed was not the ideas but the audience willing to buy them, and the medium—CBS radio and television—through which they were amplified.

5.2 Cultural Matching and Media Amplification

I interpret Schlafly's campaign as *cultural matching*[34]. The historical timeline in Figure 7 establishes that the argument stock was old; the empirical sections establish that CBS exposure moved attitudes, votes, and rhetoric through different channels. Appendix 7.3 maps these pieces into a compact framework: dormant supply, unmatched demand, scarce entry, and platform transmission.[35] Figure 9 gives the full mechanism.

The pro-ERA movement also supplied Schlafly with ammunition she did not have to manufacture. Between 1963 and 1973, a rapid wave of legal change transformed the terrain of women's rights: the Equal Pay Act, Title VII, the erosion of protective labor laws, Title IX, the Equal Employment Opportunity Act, and congressional passage of the ERA itself (Goldin 2023). These victories changed the politics of mobilization. As equality claims became more successful in law, the movement appeared more demanding, while women attached to family roles, sex-specific protections, and religious traditionalism had clearer reasons to organize against the ERA. Figure 8 formalizes this intuition: policy victories can narrow the active equality coalition while making the stakes more salient to a rival audience.

When the National Organization for Women (NOW), founded in 1966, argued that both parents should share child-rearing responsibility, it inherited the NWP's maximalist instinct along with its egalitarian commitments (Harrison 1988). When ERA opponents asked whether the amendment meant women in combat, the pro-ERA movement answered yes, because its ideology demanded "full equality with men, not for equality with exceptions." Feminist lawyers also argued in state courts that state ERAs required publicly funded abortions (Mansbridge 1986).

Did Schlafly become vehemently anti-ERA in reaction to radical feminists? The timeline does not support that simple story. Schlafly showed no interest in the ERA until friends in Darien, Connecticut, prompted her in December 1971; she published her first anti-ERA

[34] The formal model is developed separately in the companion theory paper, *A Choice Not An Echo: Cultural Matching in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy.*

[35] The appendix keeps the formal mapping separate from the main historical narrative.

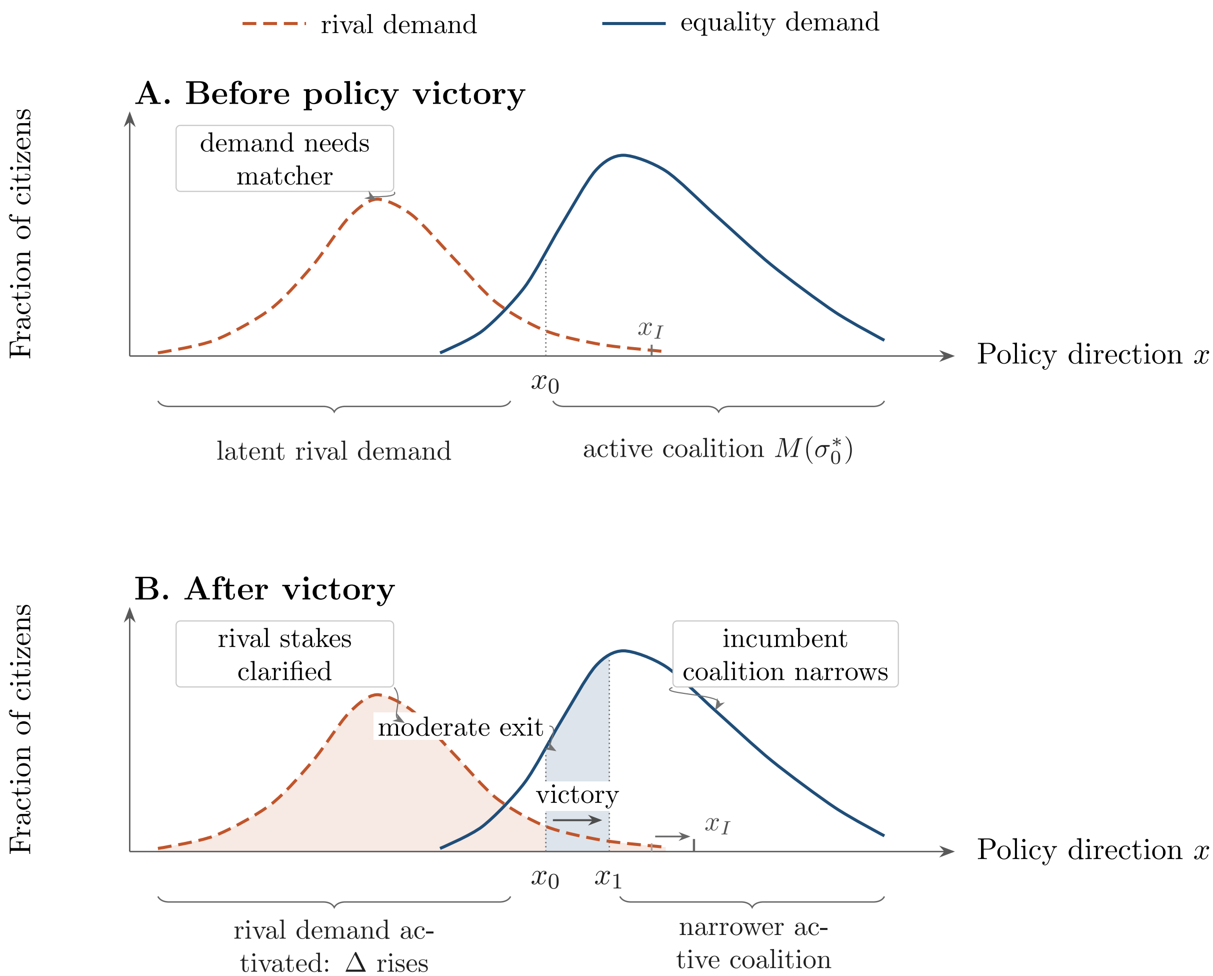

Figure 8: Coalitional narrowing and rival activation after policy victories. A partial victory moves policy from x_0 to x_1: lower-intensity supporters become less central to active mobilization, while the stakes become more salient to a rival audience. Adapted from Goldin (2023), Figure 4.

Phyllis Schlafly Report only in February 1972. By then, Ti-Grace Atkinson, who left NOW in October 1968 to form the more radical Feminists; Shulamith Firestone, whose *Dialectic of Sex* called for abolishing the nuclear family in 1970; and Kate Millett, whose *Sexual Politics* framed marriage as a patriarchal institution in 1970, had already staked out maximalist positions. Radical feminists were useful to Schlafly not as genuine catalysts but as foils.

Schlafly's more immediate antagonists were the moderate Republican women—Elly Peterson, Gladys O'Donnell, and others in the NFRW establishment—who had blocked her from institutional power and pushed her to start her own network of conservative women in August 1967 with the *Phyllis Schlafly Report* and the Eagle Trust Fund. Schlafly could not attack those moderates directly without alienating the broader Republican base. Instead, in her November 1972 *Phyllis Schlafly Report*, she exploited radical feminist positions by separating "professional women" from "women liberationists who want to destroy morality and family." By casting the ERA as the vehicle of radical feminism rather than the mainstream bipartisan measure it appeared to be, she made moderate women's support seem naive, gave homemakers permission to oppose the amendment and professional women permission to stay out, and positioned herself as the reasonable voice against extremism. She was not creating new anxieties; she was activating dormant ones that the women's movement's unresolved equality-and-motherhood problem had left available for fifty years.

Her audience had been primed by a half-century of unresolved questions after suffrage. History alone, however, cannot tell us whether her CBS platform causally amplified those arguments; Section 3 provides the main legislative evidence, and Section 4 shows the corroborating public-opinion pattern. The remaining question is why old claims became politically effective when Schlafly carried them to a new audience.

Despite their pivotal role in cultural change (Acemoglu and Robinson 2025; Mokyr 2017; North 1981; Schumpeter 1911; Swedberg 2006; Storr 2009), specific entrepreneurs are difficult to measure. Cultural entrepreneurship has two components: framing, or what the entrepreneur says, and performance, or how she says it. The empirical evidence focuses on framing because semantic similarity between legislators' speeches and the *Phyllis Schlafly Report* can measure it; Appendix 7.3 gives the broader cultural-matching account of how framing, networks, and media platforms activate latent political demand.

As Schlafly put it: "Your choice of words can sell a product, an issue, or a candidate ... can mean the difference between making the sale or leaving empty-handed" (Schlafly 2000). She reframed abstract rights as concrete threats: the draft for daughters, loss of alimony and child support, lower Social Security benefits, higher life insurance premiums, and judicial protection for criminals and radicals. The strategy succeeded: CBS TV and AM exposure both independently increased legislators' adoption of Schlafly's framing in Table 14. Legislators in CBS-covered districts used her vocabulary, her argumentative structure, and her issue bundling. Schlafly changed not just how legislators voted but how they talked.

The positive NBC coefficient in Table 12 is consistent with a strong pro-ERA constituency that responded to general media coverage. That constituency, however, was less organized at the margin. The concentrated, organized minority led by Schlafly dominated the diffuse majority (Olson 1965). When asked about "the array of forces in favor of ERA in '72, '73 seemed overwhelming," Schlafly recalled that the pro-ERA side "had Congress ... Nixon, Ford and Carter ... all the governors. Some of the governors would march in demonstrations against us. They had 99 percent of the media ... Hollywood ... organized forces everywhere."

The ERA lost at the margins by three states, not because Americans suddenly opposed equal rights, but because ERA opponents were better organized and had more effective messaging. Meanwhile, support for the amendment was structurally fragile (Mansbridge 1986). Schlafly converted structural vulnerability into public opinion, votes, and legislative rhetoric. By keeping the ERA in the negative news cycle and questioning its necessity, Schlafly made supporting the ERA that much harder.

6 Conclusion

What killed the ERA, and who helped make its defeat possible? The evidence shows that Phyllis Schlafly's CBS platform changed legislative behavior, with corroborating evidence that the same platform moved public opinion in the pivotal states. The strongest evidence comes from Illinois, where the archive links broadcast exposure to both roll-call votes and floor speech. CBS FM exposure reduced legislators' probability of voting for the ERA by

39.7 pp, while CBS TV exposure increased their adoption of Schlafly's framing by 17.1 pp. A geochemical IV for CBS AM exposure independently increased framing adoption by 16.8 pp.[36] These effects persist after controlling for pre-existing conservative networks, religious composition, and legislator characteristics.

The five-state ANES estimates corroborate that legislative pattern. Counties exposed to Schlafly's weekly CBS FM commentaries after 1974 saw a 0.21 standard-deviation decline in sentiment toward women's rights relative to unexposed counties. Because the survey data provide limited pre-treatment leverage for conventional pre-trend tests, I interpret this as supporting evidence rather than the paper's main causal estimate. The pattern across channels is nevertheless informative: FM radio appears to have operated through mass attitudes and constituent pressure, while TV and AM carried a reusable frame into legislative speech. The results therefore point to the content of Schlafly's CBS platform, not general media consumption alone.

The historical mechanism is equally important. Schlafly did not invent the major anti-ERA arguments. Schlafly's contribution was to match those arguments to a new audience—homemakers and religious conservatives whose anxieties were not organized by the existing debate—and to amplify the match through CBS. The arguments against the ERA were old; CBS made them mobile and public, giving Schlafly reach through FM radio in cars, television in homes, and AM radio across broader areas, beyond what any newsletter, STOP ERA chapter, or state-level campaign could have achieved alone. In Illinois, those arguments arrived in the General Assembly in the mouths of legislators who spoke as if they had read the *Phyllis Schlafly Report*.

The mechanism generalizes beyond the ERA. Schlafly's campaign built political machinery that outlived the amendment, leaving structural and rhetorical infrastructure for later conservative movements.[37] The dominant view treats culture as moving through broad social forces such as economic development and generational replacement. I offer a complementary account: during periods of social upheaval, cultural entrepreneurs with media platforms can reshape major constitutional outcomes. The ERA's defeat was neither inevitable nor accidental. Schlafly won by matching message, medium, and audience at the moment when unaddressed anxieties became politically consequential.

References

Acemoglu, Daron and James A. Robinson (June 2025). "Culture, Institutions, and Social Equilibria: A Framework". *Journal of Economic Literature* 63.2, pp. 637–692. DOI: 10.1257/jel.20241680.

Celler, Emanuel (Feb. 1964). *Remarks on Amendment to Title VII of H.R. 7152*. Congressional Record, Vol. 110, Part 2. 88th Congress, 2nd Session.

Critchlow, Donald T. (2005). *Phyllis Schlafly and Grassroots Conservatism: A Woman's Crusade*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

[36]Scaled effects are reported in Table 15.

[37]Schlafly explicitly named Donald Trump as the heir to the movement she built in her final 2016 book, *The Conservative Case for Trump*. Trump eulogized Schlafly as a "truly great American patriot" and a key figure in the "America First" movement.

Dallek, Matthew (2023). *Birchers: How the John Birch Society radicalized the American right*. Basic Books.

Dell, Melissa (Mar. 2025). "Deep Learning for Economists". *Journal of Economic Literature* 63.1, pp. 5–58. DOI: 10.1257/jel.20241733.

DeMinco, Nicholas (1986). *Ground-wave Analysis Model For MF Broadcast System*. NTIA Report 86-203. Boulder, CO: NTIA.

— (1999). *Medium Frequency Propagation Prediction Techniques and Antenna Modeling for Intelligent Transportation Systems (ITS) Broadcast Applications*. NTIA Report 99-368. Boulder, CO: NTIA.

DePue, Mark (2011). *Interview with Phyllis Schlafly*. Abraham Lincoln Presidential Library Oral History Program, ISE-A-L-2011-001.01.

Devlin, Jacob et al. (2019). "BERT: Pre-training of Deep Bidirectional Transformers for Language Understanding". In: *NAACL*.

Freund, Paul A. (Mar. 1971). "The Equal Rights Amendment Is Not the Way". *Harvard Civil Rights-Civil Liberties Law Review* 6.2, pp. 234–242.

Goldin, Claudia (Oct. 2023). *Why Women Won*. Working Paper 31762. NBER. DOI: 10.3386/w31762.

Harrison, Cynthia (1988). *On Account of Sex: The Politics of Women's Issues, 1945–1968*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Held, Allison L., Sheryl L. Herndon, and Danielle M. Stager (1997). "The Equal Rights Amendment: Why the ERA Remains Legally Viable and Properly Before the States". *William & Mary Journal of Women and the Law* 3.1. Article 5, pp. 113–136. URL: https://scholarship.law.wm.edu/wmjowl/vol3/iss1/5.

Hufford, G.A., A.G. Longley, and W.A. Kissick (Apr. 1982). *A Guide to the Use of the ITS Irregular Terrain Model in the Area Prediction Mode*. Tech. rep. NTIA Report 82-100. NTIA.

Lazar, Ernie (2020). *Schlafly, Phyllis and John Birch Society*. Archival documents including correspondence. URL: archive.org (visited on 03/16/2025).

Lee, David S. et al. (Oct. 2022). "Valid t-Ratio Inference for IV". *American Economic Review* 112.10, pp. 3260–3290. DOI: 10.1257/aer.20211063.

Longley, Anita and Paul Rice (1968). *Prediction of Tropospheric Radio Transmission Loss Over Irregular Terrain: A Computer Method*. Tech. rep. ERL 79-ITS 67. NTIA.

Mansbridge, Jane (1986). *Why we lost the ERA*. University of Chicago Press.

Mokyr, Joel (2017). *A culture of growth: The origins of the modern economy*. Princeton University Press.

North, Douglass (1981). *Structure and change in economic history*. W. W. Norton & Co., Inc.

Olken, Benjamin A. (Oct. 2009). "Do Television and Radio Destroy Social Capital? Evidence from Indonesian Villages". *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 1.4, pp. 1–33. DOI: 10.1257/app.1.4.1.

Olson, Mancur (1965). *The Logic of Collective Action*. Harvard University Press.

Radford, Alec et al. (2018). *Improving Language Understanding by Generative Pre-Training*. Tech. rep. OpenAI.

Reimers, Nils and Iryna Gurevych (2019). "Sentence-BERT: Sentence Embeddings Using Siamese BERT-Networks". In: *EMNLP-IJCNLP*.

Sanders, Frank H. (June 2010). *Derivations of Relationships among Field Strength, Power in Transmitter-Receiver Circuits and Radiation Hazard Limits*. Technical Memorandum TM-10-469. Boulder, CO: NTIA.

Schlafly, Phyllis (2000). *Speech at 29th Eagle Council Training*. Eagle Forum.

Schulenberg, Ray and Olin Shuler (2015). "The First Broadcast FM Auto Radio: Motorola FM-900". *The AWA Review* 28, pp. 73–86.

Schumpeter, Joseph (1911). *Theorie der wirtschaftlichen entwicklung*.

Spruill, Marjorie (2017). *Divided we stand: The battle over women's rights and family values that polarized American politics*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

Steinem, Gloria and Eleanor Smeal (July 30, 2020). *Why 'Mrs. America' is bad for American women*. Los Angeles Times. URL: `https://www.latimes.com/entertainment-arts/tv/story/2020-07-30/steinem-and-smeal-why-mrs-america-is-bad-for-american-women` (visited on 02/06/2026).

Storr, Virgil (2009). "North's Underdeveloped Ideological Entrepreneur". In: *The Annual Proceedings of the Wealth and Well-Being of Nations*. Vol. 1. Beloit College.

Swedberg, Richard (2006). "Social entrepreneurship: The view of the young Schumpeter". In: *Entrepreneurship as social change*. Ed. by Chris Steyaert and Daniel Hjorth. Edward Elgar Publishing.

Vaswani, Ashish et al. (2017). "Attention Is All You Need". In: *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*. Vol. 30.

7 Appendix

7.1 Measuring Semantic Similarity

Figure 5 summarizes the measurement pipeline. I use semantic similarity to measure rhetorical framing, not agreement with Schlafly's position. I embed each legislator speech and each issue of the *Phyllis Schlafly Report* with Sentence-BERT (Reimers and Gurevych 2019), a bi-encoder model that maps texts into vectors. I then compute cosine similarity for each speech-newsletter pair. Higher values indicate that a legislator's language is semantically closer to the language in the relevant PSR issue.

Sentence-BERT fits this task for two reasons. First, contextual embeddings represent words according to their surrounding language. For example, "right" can mean correct, conservative, or a direction; contextual embeddings assign different representations to those uses. Contextual embedding matters because legislators could adopt Schlafly's arguments without repeating her exact words. The attention mechanism underlying contextual embeddings therefore helps capture paraphrase rather than only verbatim overlap.[38] Second, Sentence-BERT's contrastive pretraining learns a metric space in which similar text pairs are pushed together and dissimilar text pairs are pulled apart.[39] The measure is therefore suited to detecting rhetorical adoption: legislators using Schlafly's framework should appear

[38]The attention mechanism (Vaswani et al. 2017) gives rise to LLMs like BERT (Devlin et al. 2019) and GPT (Radford et al. 2018).

[39]This bi-encoder similarity approach has also been shown to perform well in disambiguating newspaper articles and OCR applications (Dell 2025).

closer to the PSR even when they do not quote it directly.

The Dyer example illustrates the logic. In the February 1973 PSR, Schlafly wrote that the ERA text could be read to permit "reasonable legal classifications" by sex, but that another interpretation of "equality" would require "identical" treatment and "compel the courts to interpret the new Amendment as a mandate to sweep away all statutory sex distinctions." Two months later, the staunchly pro-ERA legislator Goudyloch E. Dyer used strikingly similar language while reaching the opposite political conclusion: "A policy under the law does not mean sameness. There can still be reasonable classifications of people based on functions and capability, not just arbitrary distinctions on the basis of sex. Of course, it's not going to wipe out all of the differences based on sex."[40]

The same example clarifies why semantic similarity measures framing rather than agreement. Dyer adopted the language of "reasonable classifications" while supporting the ERA. More generally, a legislator could use Schlafly's framing to endorse it, reject it, mock it, or reassure constituents that its implications were overstated. I therefore analyze roll-call votes and rhetorical similarity as separate outcomes. Figure 12 plots the distribution of semantic similarity scores separately for YES and NO votes. The unconditional relationship is small, even when statistically significant, suggesting that rhetorical adoption captures a dimension of legislative behavior distinct from roll-call voting.

7.2 Limitations and Extensions

Three limitations remain. First, the five pivotal states were politically contested and may have unobservable characteristics that limit generalizability. The expanded ANES results for CBS TV and FM in the lower 48 and in non-ratifying states partly address this concern by showing whether the main patterns hold beyond the pivotal-state sample. The ANES analysis also has limited pre-treatment survey support for parallel trends, which is why I present it as corroborating evidence rather than the paper's primary causal claim. I am still digitizing the comparable AM analysis for the non-ratifying states and lower 48, so the AM results should be interpreted more narrowly.

Second, the estimates identify the marginal effect of local CBS exposure beyond whatever national baseline shift Schlafly's campaign produced. If Schlafly changed national discourse, then even control counties received some treatment. The estimates therefore understate her total influence. Estimating that broader effect would require a different design, one that compares places with and without any meaningful Schlafly presence rather than places with stronger or weaker CBS reception.

Finally, future work could separate signal availability from actual audience exposure. The current estimates are reduced-form intent-to-treat effects: they measure the effect of predicted CBS availability, not the structural effect of watching or listening. Digitized TV Factbook viewership estimates by network and county could support a first-stage estimate for television viewership. Comparable radio rescaling is harder because AM and FM listenership data from Arbitron are organized by radio market rather than county, requiring historical radio-market boundary maps to be converted into GIS shapefiles.

[40]The model gave this text pair a cosine similarity of 0.821.

7.3 Cultural Matching Framework

This appendix applies the companion theory paper's cultural-matching framework to the ERA setting. The goal is to clarify the primitives that organize the empirical pattern, not to introduce a second empirical design. I use *cultural matching* to describe episodes in which old arguments become politically active when three conditions coincide: a dormant argument stock, an audience whose anxieties are not represented by the dominant public frame, and an entrepreneur with the networks and incentives to connect them. The matcher makes an old argument newly visible to the audience for whom it becomes politically meaningful. Broadcast platforms then determine which observable outcomes move.

The framework separates stock, demand, entry, and platform transmission. Old arguments accumulate as a stock, $S(t)$, sitting unused in congressional debates, legal memoranda, organizational archives, newsletters, and movement repertoires. Social change can produce unmatched demand, $\Delta(t)$, among citizens whose anxieties are not well represented by the dominant public framing. Entry is scarce because the entrepreneur needs access to prior repertoires, runway to search the archive and recognize a viable configuration before returns arrive, a weak conventional outside option, and tolerance for political risk.

Once the entrepreneur activates a match, the platform maps the same frame into different outcomes through two exposure margins: volume V and density ρ. Volume is the extensive margin, $V = R \times T(F)$: repetition multiplied by fidelity-adjusted take-up. Density is the intensive margin, $\rho = C \times I(F)$: frame coherence multiplied by an intelligibility condition. In the empirical design, coverage supplies assignment and identifying variation; in the framework, exposure operates through effective contacts and usable frame content.

The volume-density distinction clarifies cases that otherwise look puzzling. CBS AM has lower fidelity than television, which lowers take-up and therefore volume; conditional on intelligible reception, however, scripted commentary can still have high density. NBC television illustrates the opposite case: repeated network-news coverage generates high volume, but diffuse reporting carries little reusable frame content per hit. ABC television is low volume but high density when fewer contacts nevertheless carry a coherent rival vocabulary.

Figure 9 summarizes the mechanism. Figure 10 opens the platform box by distinguishing inputs that change the number of effective contacts from inputs that change the amount of usable frame content carried by each intelligible contact. Table 1 fixes the technology assignments, and Figure 11 displays those assignments as a four-quadrant exposure map.

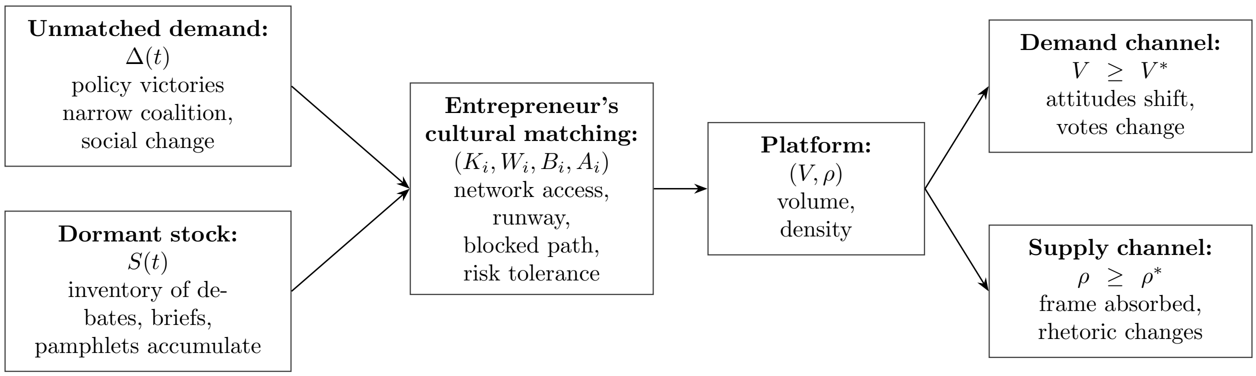

Figure 9: The cultural matching mechanism. Demand and supply accumulate separately; the entrepreneur is the matching technology connecting them; the platform converts the match into political outcomes through the extensive and intensive margins of exposure.

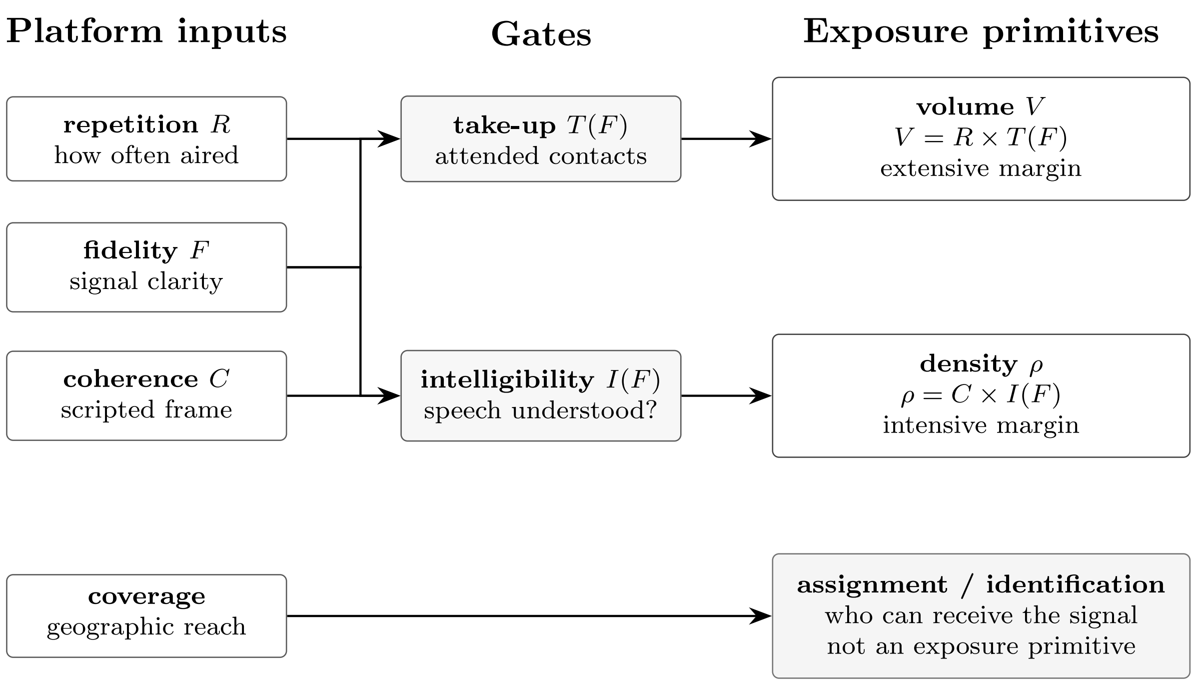

Figure 10: From platform inputs to exposure primitives. Repetition and fidelity-adjusted take-up determine volume $V = R \times T(F)$; coherence and intelligibility determine density $\rho = C \times I(F)$. Fidelity enters through take-up and intelligibility, while coverage governs assignment and identifying variation rather than exposure intensity.

Table 1: Exposure Characteristics and Expected Empirical Patterns by Technology

Technology	Frame / exposure space	Volume V	Density ρ	Expected empirical pattern
CBS FM	Schlafly frame	High: looped radio programming and repeated in-car contact	High: complete scripted *Spectrum* commentary delivered intact	Both channels: attitude and vote effects; similarity need not track low-volume CBS rhetoric effects
CBS TV	Schlafly frame	Low: one fixed morning slot, limited repeated contact	High: full audiovisual delivery preserves the argumentative frame	Supply channel: rhetoric/similarity effect; no vote effect
CBS AM	Schlafly frame	Low effective contact: looped schedule but low take-up under fuzzy audio	High conditional on intelligible reception: spoken delivery preserves the commentary	Supply channel: rhetoric/similarity effect; no vote effect
PBS TV	Schlafly-adjacent frame	Low: lower-volume, narrow/elite deliberative exposure	High: debate/interview format preserves arguments, though not identical CBS content	Supply channel: speaking/rhetoric effect; no vote effect; outside identical-content CBS test
NBC TV	Rival pro-ERA frame	High: frequent network-news coverage creates repeated pro-ERA salience	Low: diffuse reporting does not preserve one portable rival script	Rival demand channel: pro-ERA vote/attitude pressure; little PSR-similarity effect
ABC TV	Rival pro-ERA frame	Low: less repeated effective network-news exposure than NBC	High: when covered, the rival vocabulary is coherent and reusable	Rival supply channel: rhetoric shifts away from Schlafly/PSR; no vote effect

Notes: The assignments are ex ante classifications based on engineering, scheduling, repetition, take-up, frame coherence, and intelligibility inputs rather than outcome coefficients. Volume V is the extensive margin, $R \times T(F)$: repetition multiplied by fidelity-adjusted take-up. Density ρ is the intensive margin, $C \times I(F)$: frame coherence multiplied by an intelligibility condition. Filled points in Figure 11 are plotted in Schlafly-frame exposure space; open points are plotted in the rival frame's own exposure space, so the network-news rows classify rival-content exposure rather than Schlafly exposure. Coverage determines treatment assignment and identifying variation, not per-contact frame content. The empirical estimates test whether outcomes align with these ex ante assignments.

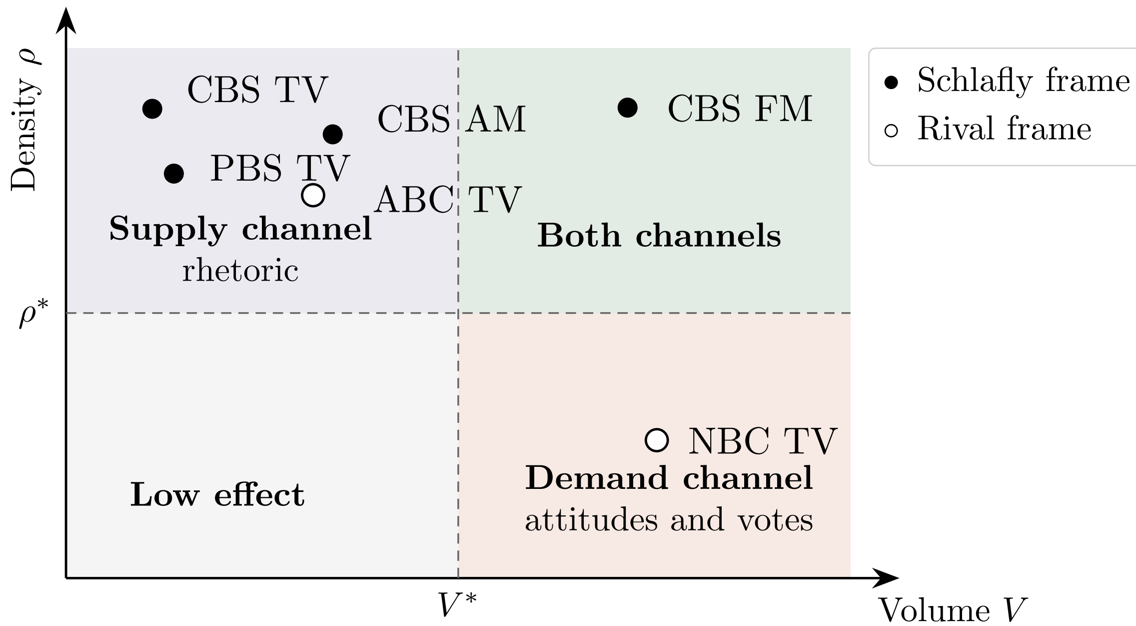

Figure 11: Platform map in exposure space. Technologies carrying Schlafly's frame are filled points; rival-content technologies are open points and should be read in the rival frame's own exposure space. CBS FM lies in the high-volume/high-density cell, consistent with attitude and vote effects. CBS TV and CBS AM lie in the high-density/low-volume cell, consistent with rhetoric effects without vote effects. NBC and ABC occupy rival-frame cells: NBC is high-volume/low-density, while ABC is low-volume/high-density. The map is a four-quadrant classification of volume and density; the companion theory paper develops the fuller formal decomposition.

The platform map visualizes the table rather than adding a new empirical object. The table classifies each technology by volume and density before the evidence turns to outcomes. The map is deliberately limited to those two exposure dimensions.[41] FM occupies the both-channels cell; the estimates then show how that joint exposure translated into attitudes, votes, and semantic similarity.

[41]The companion theory paper adds a controversy margin that can separate mass persuasion from elite rhetorical adoption within high-volume media. I omit that decomposition here because the empirical map classifies technologies only by volume and density.

8 Tables & Figures

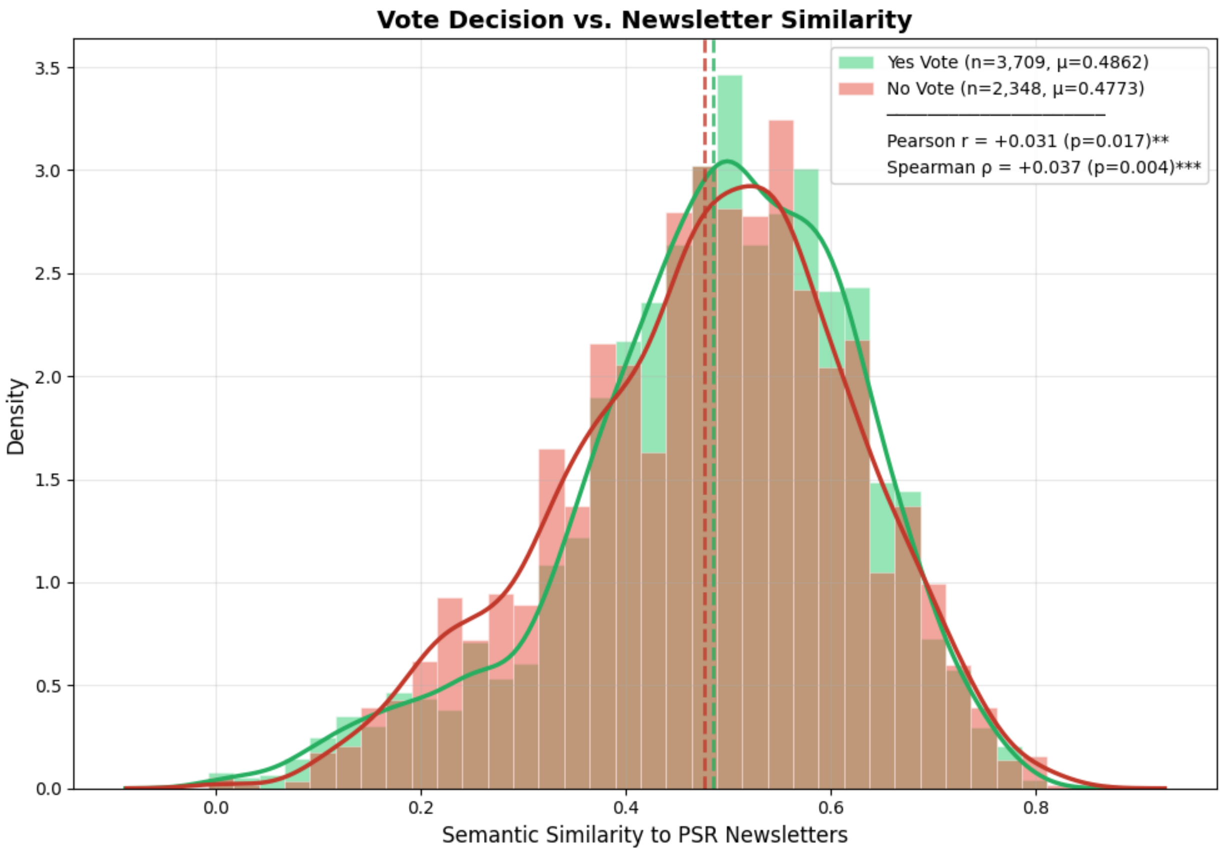

Figure 12: Vote v. Semantic Similarity Comparison (1972-1980)

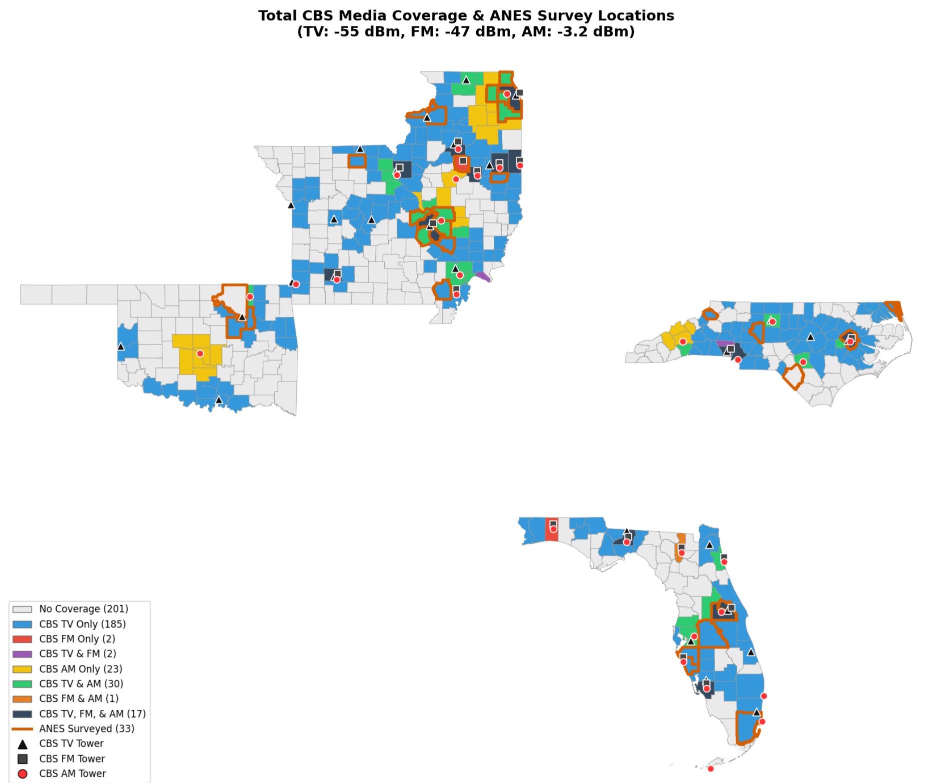

Figure 13: CBS Radio & TV Variation Coverage Map on ANES Sample

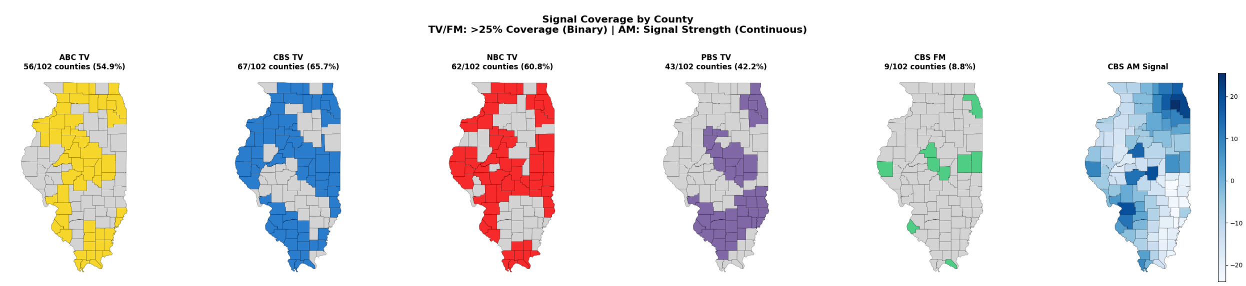

Figure 14: Illinois Network Coverage Map by County

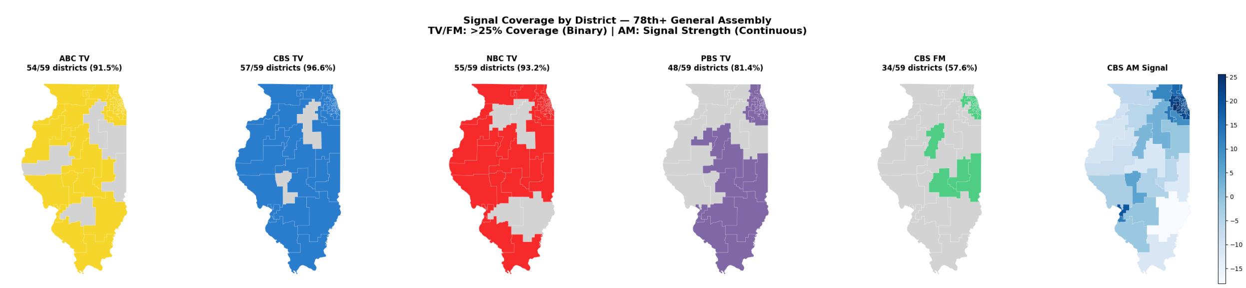

Figure 15: Illinois Network Coverage Map by District

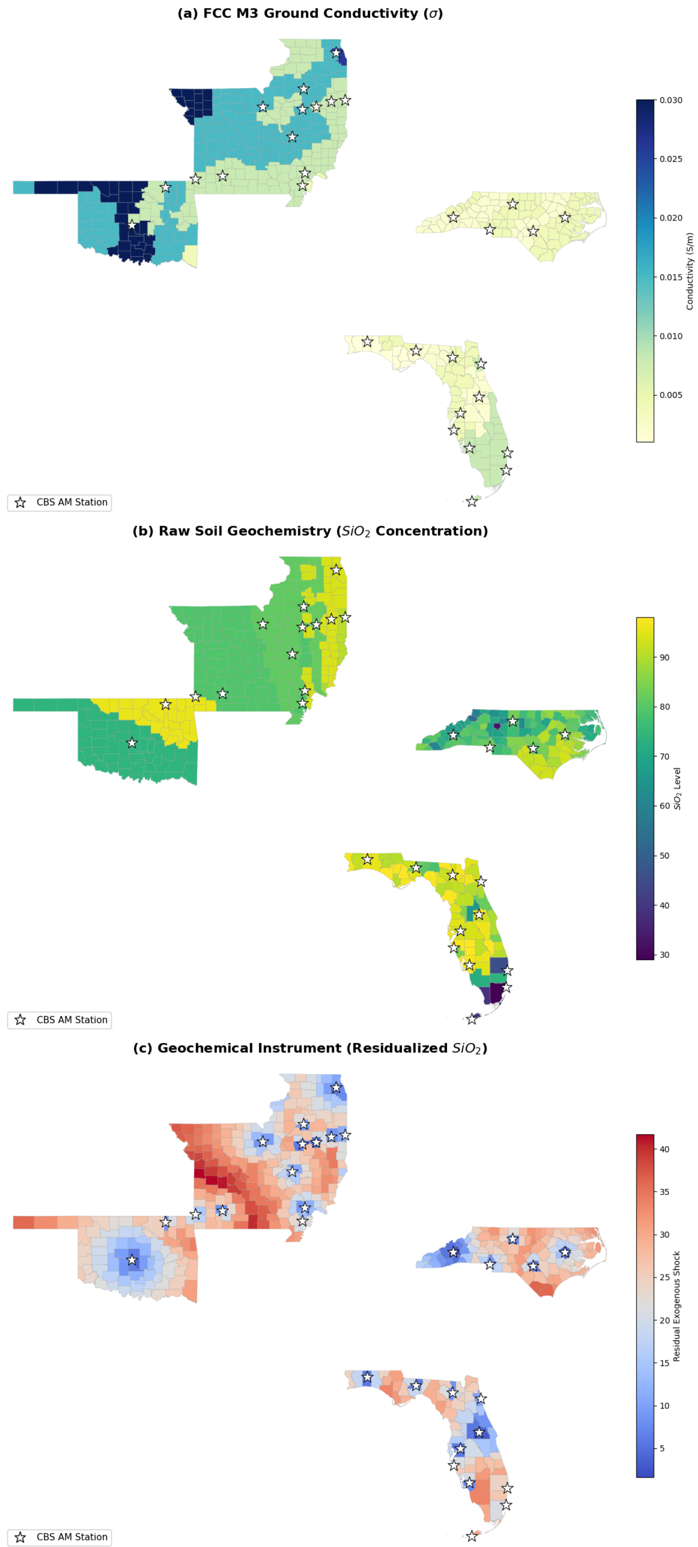

Figure 16: AM Radio Identification Strategy

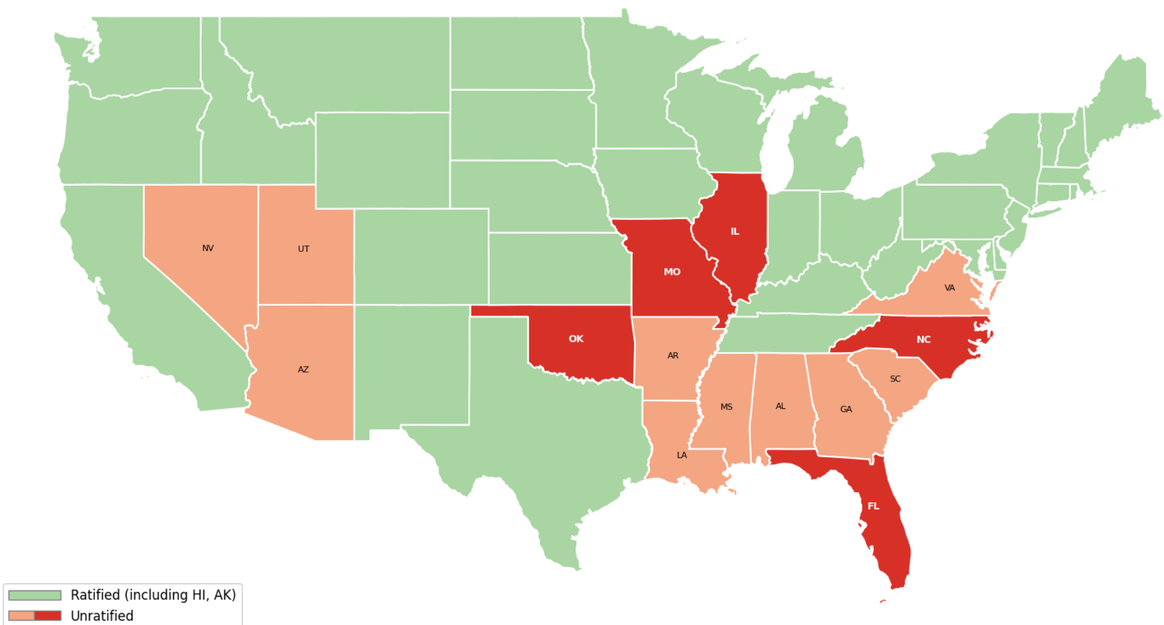

Figure 17: ERA Ratification by 1982

Table 2: ANES Summary Statistics for the Pivotal States

	N	Mean	SD
Outcome			
Women's Rights sentiment	1,927	0.613	0.350
Women's Movement sentiment	1,466	0.467	0.265
Networks			
CBS TV Exposed	2,422	0.905	0.294
CBS FM Exposed	2,422	0.320	0.467
CBS AM Signal	2,422	0.000	1.000
County Controls			
JBS Member	2,422	0.588	0.492
Evangelical %	2,422	0.144	0.119
Catholic %	2,422	0.128	0.140
Mainline Protestant %	2,422	0.168	0.092
Respondent Controls			
Mainline Protestant	2,422	0.357	0.479
Evangelical	2,422	0.386	0.487
Catholic	2,422	0.149	0.356
Jewish	2,422	0.017	0.131
Non-Trad. Orthodox	2,422	0.012	0.107
Non-Christian/Jewish	2,422	0.004	0.064
Female	2,422	0.551	0.498

Notes: Sample is limited to FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK. Women's Rights sentiment is the equal-role scale, reverse-coded and mapped to $[0, 1]$, so higher values indicate more egalitarian sentiment. Women's Movement sentiment is the ANES thermometer divided by 100 after dropping special codes 98 and 99. CBS TV and FM exposure are binary strong signal indicators; CBS AM signal is normalized. Respondent reference categories are Male and No Religion.

Table 3: ANES Balance by Baseline CBS FM Coverage across 5 States

	Unexposed	Exposed	Difference
CBS TV coverage indicator	0.937	0.835	-0.103^{***}
County: JBS Member	0.492	0.792	0.300^{***}
County: Evangelical	0.183	0.061	-0.122^{***}
County: Catholic	0.090	0.208	0.118^{***}
County: Mainline Protestant	0.186	0.130	-0.057^{***}
Respondent: Mainline Protestant	0.358	0.355	-0.003
Respondent: Evangelical	0.412	0.329	-0.083
Respondent: Catholic	0.131	0.187	0.057
Respondent: Jewish	0.011	0.031	0.020^{**}
Respondent: Non-Trad. Orthodox	0.009	0.018	0.010^{*}
Respondent: Non-Christian/Non-Jewish	0.004	0.004	-0.000
Respondent: Female	0.548	0.557	0.010

Notes: The table compares respondents in counties with and without baseline CBS FM coverage in the five pivotal ERA states: FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK. Differences report the raw exposed and unexposed difference in means. Significance stars are based on row-specific balance regressions that include state fixed effects: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Raw outcome means by CBS FM exposure status are reported separately in Table 10.

Table 4: Post-1974 CBS Exposure on Equal Role Scale

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: OLS				
CBS TV exposure	-0.129	0.417***	0.213	0.266
	(0.182)	(0.137)	(0.207)	(0.192)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.267***	-0.322	-0.244	-0.285
	(0.066)	(0.227)	(0.204)	(0.209)
CBS FM exposure	0.177	0.250**	0.108	0.127
	(0.127)	(0.093)	(0.119)	(0.121)
CBS FM × Post-1974	-0.127	-0.236**	-0.203**	-0.213**
	(0.095)	(0.106)	(0.098)	(0.094)
Panel B: OLS				
CBS TV exposure	-0.128	0.284	0.203	0.237
	(0.123)	(0.188)	(0.208)	(0.189)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.227***	-0.169	-0.116	-0.163
	(0.060)	(0.245)	(0.225)	(0.222)
CBS AM exposure	-0.055	-0.018	0.007	0.005
	(0.076)	(0.141)	(0.142)	(0.133)
CBS AM × Post-1974	0.003	0.075	0.061	0.038
	(0.059)	(0.114)	(0.106)	(0.104)
Panel C: SiO_2 IV				
CBS TV exposure	-0.153	0.178	0.145	0.168
	(0.131)	(0.200)	(0.221)	(0.205)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.242***	-0.114	-0.086	-0.109
	(0.050)	(0.264)	(0.250)	(0.248)
CBS AM exposure	-0.010	0.135	0.023	0.047
	(0.108)	(0.103)	(0.143)	(0.135)
CBS AM × Post-1974	-0.118**	-0.073	-0.057	-0.066
	(0.052)	(0.046)	(0.042)	(0.040)
First-stage F	91.2	122.4	121.0	121.1
State × Year FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent Controls[b]	No	Yes	No	Yes
County Controls[c]	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,927	1,927	1,927	1,927

[a] Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by county; *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.
[b] Religion, Gender
[c] JBS Member (0/1), Religious composition (%)
Notes: Sample is limited to the five pivotal ERA states: FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK. Each panel reports both exposure-level coefficients and exposure × Post-1974 coefficients. AM signal is continuous; panels B and C are estimated jointly with CBS TV and AM. Strong signal thresholds: TV −55 dBm (47 CFR §73.683); FM −47 dBm (47 CFR §73.315). Outcomes are standardized such that coefficients are in standard deviations.

Table 5: Post-1974 CBS Exposure on Women's Movement Thermometer

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: OLS				
CBS TV exposure	-0.308	0.146*	0.557***	0.547***
	(0.268)	(0.081)	(0.125)	(0.122)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.327***	-0.002	-0.024	0.012
	(0.092)	(0.149)	(0.124)	(0.140)
CBS FM exposure	-0.063	0.018	0.246*	0.253*
	(0.121)	(0.115)	(0.130)	(0.133)
CBS FM × Post-1974	0.223**	0.145	0.081	0.082
	(0.101)	(0.091)	(0.097)	(0.100)
Panel B: OLS				
CBS TV exposure	-0.353**	0.059	0.229	0.208
	(0.146)	(0.112)	(0.162)	(0.159)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.404***	-0.020	-0.033	0.003
	(0.071)	(0.186)	(0.172)	(0.185)
CBS AM exposure	-0.095	-0.155	-0.165	-0.172
	(0.063)	(0.128)	(0.138)	(0.140)
CBS AM × Post-1974	0.001	0.126	0.137	0.140
	(0.071)	(0.151)	(0.157)	(0.157)
Panel C: SiO_2 IV				
CBS TV exposure	-0.368*	0.190***	0.306**	0.284**
	(0.196)	(0.068)	(0.137)	(0.133)
CBS TV × Post-1974	0.405***	-0.171	-0.192	-0.159
	(0.072)	(0.129)	(0.123)	(0.136)
CBS AM exposure	-0.212**	-0.157	-0.007	0.039
	(0.094)	(0.120)	(0.098)	(0.092)
CBS AM × Post-1974	0.042	0.079	0.060	0.059
	(0.056)	(0.047)	(0.047)	(0.047)
First-stage F	113.0	153.0	151.2	151.0
State × Year FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent Controls[b]	No	Yes	No	Yes
County Controls[c]	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,466	1,466	1,466	1,466

Notes: Same sample, exposure definitions, controls, standard-error clustering, and significance thresholds as Table 4.

Table 6: ANES Full Specification Controls

	Women's Rights	Women's Movement
Panel A: TV + FM (OLS)		
CBS TV × Post-1974	-0.285	0.012
	(0.209)	(0.140)
CBS FM × Post-1974	-0.213**	0.082
	(0.094)	(0.100)
County: JBS Member	-0.085	-0.294***
	(0.068)	(0.080)
County: Catholic %	0.984***	0.190
	(0.302)	(0.309)
County: Evangelical %	-0.797***	-0.021
	(0.262)	(0.382)
County: Mainline Protestant %	-0.097	1.046***
	(0.236)	(0.270)
Resp: Mainline Protestant	-0.330***	-0.300***
	(0.086)	(0.083)
Resp: Evangelical	-0.540***	-0.223**
	(0.081)	(0.094)
Resp: Catholic	-0.365***	-0.095
	(0.109)	(0.115)
Resp: Jewish	-0.277***	0.146
	(0.077)	(0.091)
Resp: Non-Trad. Orthodox	-0.423*	-0.182
	(0.219)	(0.113)
Resp: Non-Christian/Jewish	0.007	0.179
	(0.259)	(0.370)
Resp: Female	-0.112**	-0.052
	(0.049)	(0.049)
Adjusted R^2	0.085	0.091
Panel B: TV + AM (SiO_2 IV)		
CBS AM (IV) × Post-1974	-0.066	0.059
	(0.040)	(0.047)
First-stage F	121.1	151.0
State × Year FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,927	1,466

Notes: Sample is limited to FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK. Coefficients are from the full specifications. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by county. Reference categories are No Religion and Male. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table 7: Sensitivity to Signal Threshold

	Strong[a]	Medium[b]	Weak[c]
Equal Role Scale			
CBS TV × Post-1974	-0.182	—	—
	(0.211)		
CBS FM × Post-1974	-0.172**	-0.192**	-0.017
	(0.081)	(0.081)	(0.155)
CBS AM (IV) × Post-1974	-0.075**	—	—
	(0.034)		
First-stage F	152.2	—	—
Women's Movement Thermometer			
CBS TV × Post-1974	-0.066	—	—
	(0.138)		
CBS FM × Post-1974	0.107	0.102	-0.404***
	(0.095)	(0.096)	(0.099)
CBS AM (IV) × Post-1974	0.052	—	—
	(0.044)		
First-stage F	184.2	—	—
State × Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
County Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes

[a] **Strong** TV: −55 dBm (Robust reception; aligns with High VHF Grade B, 56 dBu, 47 CFR §73.683); FM: −47 dBm (FM city grade contour, 70 dBu, 47 CFR §73.315)

[b] **Medium** TV: −63 dBm (Primary service boundary; aligns with Low VHF Grade B, 47 dBu, 47 CFR §73.683); FM: −57 dBm (FM service contour, 60 dBu, 47 CFR §73.213)

[c] **Weak** TV: −75 dBm (Fringe reception limit); FM: −77 dBm (FM co-channel interfering contour, 40 dBu, 47 CFR §73.213)

Notes: Sample is limited to FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK. Each TV/FM coefficient reports Network × Post from a separate FE+All regression for that network-threshold pair. CBS AM (IV) is estimated separately as an AM-only IV regression using continuous AM signal instrumented with SiO_2. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by county. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Outcome-specific samples differ because ANES did not administer every outcome in every year; the women's movement thermometer is unavailable in 1978 and 1982 in this analysis window. CBS TV coverage is very high in this sample, so some TV threshold terms are collinear and shown as —.

Table 8: Robustness and Mechanism-Spillover Outcomes

Sample	Outcome	CBS TV × Post	CBS FM × Post	N	States
Lower 48	Equal Role	-0.064 (0.067)	-0.053 (0.068)	12,348	41
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.026 (0.069)	0.043 (0.073)	9,647	41
	Abortion	0.153 (0.140)	-0.064 (0.103)	4,458	40
	Rights of Accused	-0.144** (0.057)	-0.135*** (0.046)	8,172	40
	Aid to Blacks	-0.051 (0.062)	-0.037 (0.070)	12,757	41
	Police Therm.	0.076 (0.060)	-0.075 (0.058)	6,853	37
	Black Militants Therm.	-0.056 (0.062)	-0.018 (0.068)	9,643	41
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	-0.061 (0.070)	-0.019 (0.084)	9,684	41
	Liberals Therm.	-0.032 (0.079)	-0.053 (0.095)	10,178	41
	Conservatives Therm.	-0.028 (0.064)	0.036 (0.079)	10,345	41
	Military Therm.	0.087 (0.057)	0.020 (0.054)	9,899	41
Unratified states	Equal Role	-0.139 (0.128)	-0.120 (0.086)	3,747	14
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.030 (0.074)	0.048 (0.085)	2,874	14
	Abortion	-0.364*** (0.114)	-0.001 (0.103)	1,541	14
	Rights of Accused	-0.201* (0.115)	-0.164*** (0.053)	2,635	14
	Aid to Blacks	-0.126 (0.115)	0.042 (0.119)	3,910	14
	Police Therm.	0.172 (0.108)	0.006 (0.092)	2,277	14
	Black Militants Therm.	0.075 (0.076)	0.112 (0.093)	2,927	14
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	-0.143 (0.102)	0.005 (0.114)	2,922	14
	Liberals Therm.	0.124 (0.242)	-0.075 (0.143)	3,067	14
	Conservatives Therm.	0.061 (0.127)	0.083 (0.130)	3,129	14
	Military Therm.	0.163* (0.082)	-0.023 (0.077)	2,993	14
Pivotal states	Equal Role	-0.285 (0.209)	-0.213** (0.094)	1,927	5
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.012 (0.140)	0.082 (0.100)	1,466	5
	Abortion	-0.016 (0.174)	-0.034 (0.137)	723	5
	Rights of Accused	-0.089 (0.077)	-0.207*** (0.059)	1,390	5
	Aid to Blacks	-0.176* (0.099)	0.016 (0.148)	2,055	5
	Police Therm.	0.242*** (0.077)	0.022 (0.109)	1,131	5
	Black Militants Therm.	0.165 (0.145)	0.167 (0.125)	1,488	5
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	-0.184 (0.212)	0.029 (0.160)	1,474	5
	Liberals Therm.	-0.365*** (0.129)	-0.094 (0.180)	1,620	5
	Conservatives Therm.	0.271 (0.194)	0.160 (0.169)	1,653	5
	Military Therm.	0.201** (0.094)	0.040 (0.091)	1,522	5

Notes: Coefficients are exposure × Post-1974 coefficients from FE+All DiD models. All models include state × year fixed effects, respondent controls, and county controls. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by county. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Outcomes are standardized. AM is excluded. Samples: Lower 48: AL, AR, AZ, CA, CO, CT, DE, FL, GA, IA, IL, IN, KS, KY, LA, MA, MD, ME, MI, MN, MO, MS, NC, NE, NH, NJ, NY, OH, OK, OR, PA, SC, SD, TN, TX, UT, VA, WA, WI, WV, WY; Unratified states: AL, AR, AZ, FL, GA, IL, LA, MO, MS, NC, OK, SC, UT, VA; Pivotal states: FL, IL, MO, NC, OK. The lower-48 file contains county-geocoded ANES observations for 41 states. ID, MT, ND, NM, NV, RI, and VT have no county-geocoded observations in the analysis years. In the unratified-state sample, NV is unavailable for the same reason. The number of states can vary across rows because some ANES outcomes are unavailable in particular state-year cells. All outcomes are drawn from ANES waves 1970–1984 where fielded; items lacking both a pre- and post-1974 wave are excluded, so the year coverage underlying each row varies by outcome.

Table 9: Cross-Sectional Robustness and Mechanism-Spillover Outcomes

Sample	Outcome	CBS TV	CBS FM	N	States
Lower 48	Equal Role	0.134*** (0.035)	0.006 (0.032)	12,348	41
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.092* (0.051)	0.078 (0.049)	9,647	41
	Abortion	0.091 (0.061)	0.065 (0.053)	4,458	40
	Rights of Accused	0.097* (0.053)	0.008 (0.052)	8,172	40
	Aid to Blacks	0.144*** (0.046)	0.102** (0.041)	12,757	41
	Police Therm.	-0.131*** (0.046)	-0.123** (0.062)	6,853	37
	Black Militants Therm.	0.074 (0.051)	0.064 (0.054)	9,643	41
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	0.159*** (0.056)	-0.005 (0.058)	9,684	41
	Liberals Therm.	0.055 (0.052)	0.073 (0.054)	10,178	41
	Conservatives Therm.	-0.063** (0.032)	0.014 (0.035)	10,345	41
	Military Therm.	-0.084** (0.034)	-0.103** (0.051)	9,899	41
Unratified states	Equal Role	0.217*** (0.051)	0.064 (0.057)	3,747	14
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.060 (0.138)	0.186** (0.078)	2,874	14
	Abortion	0.276* (0.145)	0.138 (0.087)	1,541	14
	Rights of Accused	0.306** (0.141)	0.143** (0.054)	2,635	14
	Aid to Blacks	0.223* (0.116)	0.062 (0.061)	3,910	14
	Police Therm.	-0.281** (0.104)	-0.077 (0.080)	2,277	14
	Black Militants Therm.	0.118 (0.153)	-0.018 (0.081)	2,927	14
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	0.179 (0.152)	-0.055 (0.094)	2,922	14
	Liberals Therm.	0.109 (0.181)	0.123 (0.087)	3,067	14
	Conservatives Therm.	-0.145** (0.073)	0.024 (0.047)	3,129	14
	Military Therm.	-0.262*** (0.066)	-0.000 (0.071)	2,993	14
Pivotal states	Equal Role	0.050 (0.092)	-0.042 (0.066)	1,927	5
	Women's Movement Therm.	0.563*** (0.131)	0.305*** (0.100)	1,466	5
	Abortion	-0.366** (0.163)	-0.018 (0.103)	723	5
	Rights of Accused	0.291* (0.149)	0.117 (0.090)	1,390	5
	Aid to Blacks	0.058 (0.101)	0.002 (0.072)	2,055	5
	Police Therm.	0.007 (0.267)	0.151* (0.081)	1,131	5
	Black Militants Therm.	0.318* (0.175)	0.062 (0.136)	1,488	5
	Civil Rights Leaders Therm.	0.248 (0.157)	-0.042 (0.130)	1,474	5
	Liberals Therm.	0.607*** (0.198)	0.220* (0.118)	1,620	5
	Conservatives Therm.	0.112 (0.108)	0.080 (0.064)	1,653	5
	Military Therm.	-0.082 (0.134)	0.086 (0.078)	1,522	5

Notes: Coefficients are treatment-level coefficients from cross-sectional FE+All models with no Post interaction. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by county. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Outcomes are standardized. AM is excluded. Samples: Lower 48: AL, AR, AZ, CA, CO, CT, DE, FL, GA, IA, IL, IN, KS, KY, LA, MA, MD, ME, MI, MN, MO, MS, NC, NE, NH, NJ, NY, OH, OK, OR, PA, SC, SD, TN, TX, UT, VA, WA, WI, WV, WY; Unratified states: AL, AR, AZ, FL, GA, IL, LA, MO, MS, NC, OK, SC, UT, VA; Pivotal states: FL, IL, MO, NC, OK. The lower-48 file contains county-geocoded ANES observations for 41 states. ID, MT, ND, NM, NV, RI, and VT have no county-geocoded observations in the analysis years. In the unratified-state sample, NV is unavailable for the same reason. All outcomes are drawn from ANES waves 1970–1984 where fielded.

Table 10: ANES Outcome Raw Means by CBS FM Exposure Status

Year	FM exposed	FM unexposed	Difference	FL	IL	MO	NC	OK	Total	Dropped
Panel A. Women's Rights (Equal Role Scale)										
1972	0.603	0.514	0.089**	75	127	70	118	19	409	22
1974	0.576	0.557	0.020	39	77	42	73	13	244	17
1976	0.607	0.576	0.032	64	96	51	62	8	281	106
1978	0.670	0.626	0.044	108	78	38	57	56	337	12
1980	0.655	0.640	0.015	62	52	24	30	27	195	55
1982	0.616	0.698	-0.083*	70	58	42	61	19	250	14
1984	0.712	0.694	0.018	68	59	29	55	0	211	28
Total	**0.629**	**0.606**	**0.024**	**486**	**547**	**296**	**456**	**142**	**1,927**	**254**
Panel B. Women's Movement Thermometer										
1970	0.362	0.375	-0.012	52	46	51	51	16	216	25
1972	0.423	0.407	0.017	57	94	51	106	14	322	109
1974	0.521	0.490	0.031	40	77	39	70	14	240	21
1976	0.535	0.476	0.060**	64	94	51	68	8	285	102
1980	0.505	0.471	0.034	63	60	26	29	27	205	45
1984	0.571	0.559	0.012	68	51	29	50	0	198	41
Total	**0.480**	**0.460**	**0.020**	**344**	**422**	**247**	**374**	**79**	**1,466**	**343**
Panel C. Rights of Accused										
1970	0.456	0.399	0.057	50	50	50	52	13	215	26
1972	0.519	0.430	0.089**	61	104	52	95	13	325	106
1974	0.420	0.415	0.005	39	69	37	63	12	220	41
1976	0.440	0.421	0.019	70	113	48	77	19	327	60
1978	0.396	0.388	0.007	104	71	31	44	53	303	46
Total	**0.450**	**0.412**	**0.039***	**324**	**407**	**218**	**331**	**110**	**1,390**	**279**
Panel D. ERA Support†										
1976	0.700	0.651	0.049	62	85	46	65	11	269	118
1978	0.641	0.542	0.099	91	65	25	41	46	268	81
1980	0.474	0.481	-0.007	60	52	25	28	21	186	64
Total	**0.619**	**0.567**	**0.052**	**213**	**202**	**96**	**134**	**78**	**723**	**263**

Entries are respondent-level raw means by baseline CBS FM exposure status in the five pivotal states. CBS FM exposure is measured using the 1972 radio tower and network-affiliation map and held fixed across survey years; later rows therefore compare respondents by baseline CBS FM exposure, not necessarily contemporaneous station affiliation or reception. Difference = CBS FM exposed − CBS FM unexposed. FL, IL, MO, NC, and OK columns report valid observations by state. Total is the total number of valid observations in the row. Dropped includes invalid or non-substantive ANES responses removed during outcome cleaning, including don't know, refused, not asked, and other special codes. The rows report descriptive comparisons, not causal estimates. The Difference column uses Welch two-sample t-tests comparing CBS FM-exposed and CBS FM-unexposed respondents within the row: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. † ERA Support is shown as a descriptive cross-sectional check, since this question is observed only in post-treatment years and is not used in the main difference-in-differences outcome.

Table 11: Illinois General Assembly Descriptive Statistics

	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Outcomes					
Vote on ERA	521	0.601	0.490	0.000	1.000
Spoke on ERA	1,424	0.198	0.399	0.000	1.000
Similarity to PSR	2,435	0.492	0.129	-0.007	0.837
District					
1964 Goldwater %	521	61.175	6.076	44.175	70.326
1970 Constitution No %	521	42.420	16.697	12.947	81.598
JBS Member	521	0.760	0.427	0.000	1.000
Legislator distance to JBS (mi)	521	8.927	15.148	0.000	99.570
Catholic %	521	60.058	23.058	8.918	79.256
Evangelical %	521	4.900	7.240	0.993	54.078
Mainline Protestant %	521	31.489	17.359	17.295	67.398
Other Christian %	521	1.244	0.920	0.156	5.504
Legislator					
Republican	521	0.470	0.500	0	1
Female	521	0.144	0.351	0	1
Veteran	521	0.514	0.500	0	1
Catholic	521	0.342	0.475	0	1
Jewish	521	0.044	0.206	0	1
Other Christian	521	0.065	0.247	0	1
Protestant	521	0.226	0.419	0	1
Insurance Affiliation	521	0.077	0.266	0	1

Legislator reference categories: Democrat, Male, Non-Veteran, No Religion, Non-Insurance.
Voting sample restricted to legislators who spoke.

Table 12: Legislators' ERA Vote: Illinois House (1972–1980)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: TV + FM				
CBS TV	-0.037	-0.064	-0.148	-0.141
	(0.268)	(0.257)	(0.275)	(0.259)
PBS TV	-0.161	-0.183	-0.172	-0.153
	(0.214)	(0.209)	(0.207)	(0.203)
ABC TV	0.055	0.104	-0.404	-0.341
	(0.253)	(0.269)	(0.314)	(0.315)
NBC TV	0.420	0.422	0.718***	0.686***
	(0.308)	(0.289)	(0.215)	(0.207)
CBS FM	0.200*	0.079	-0.298**	-0.397***
	(0.116)	(0.102)	(0.135)	(0.110)
Adjusted R^2	0.089	0.322	0.249	0.419
Panel B: TV + AM (OLS)				
CBS AM	-0.714**	-0.540**	-0.304	-0.290
	(0.286)	(0.229)	(0.266)	(0.250)
Panel C: TV + AM (IV)				
CBS AM	0.575***	0.417***	0.400	0.221
	(0.182)	(0.140)	(0.378)	(0.373)
First-stage F	421.5	399.4	142.6	168.0
Session FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Legislator Controls[b]	No	Yes	No	Yes
District Controls[c]	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	521	521	521	521

[a] Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by district; *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.
[b] Gender, Party, Veteran Status, Religion, Insurance-affiliated
[c] 1964 Goldwater %, 1970 IL Constitution %, Legislator Distance to JBS Member, JBS Member (0/1), 1971 Religious composition (%)
[d] TV/FM are district area-share proportions (0–1). AM is continuous z-scored signal strength (dBm).

Table 13: Legislators' ERA Speaking Decision: Illinois House (1972–1980)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: TV + FM				
CBS TV	-0.000	-0.030	0.095	-0.005
	(0.082)	(0.087)	(0.117)	(0.104)
PBS TV	0.150**	0.121*	0.194***	0.179**
	(0.067)	(0.071)	(0.064)	(0.069)
ABC TV	-0.059	-0.035	-0.196**	-0.127
	(0.076)	(0.071)	(0.086)	(0.083)
NBC TV	0.014	-0.002	-0.006	0.010
	(0.091)	(0.085)	(0.100)	(0.092)
CBS FM	-0.049	-0.007	-0.129	-0.077
	(0.069)	(0.061)	(0.093)	(0.073)
Adjusted R^2	0.010	0.119	0.068	0.141
Panel B: TV + AM (OLS)				
CBS AM	-0.082	-0.149*	-0.168	-0.223**
	(0.096)	(0.087)	(0.126)	(0.089)
Panel C: TV + AM (IV)				
CBS AM	-0.009	0.006	0.149	0.081
	(0.091)	(0.087)	(0.226)	(0.191)
First-stage F	568.5	604.6	170.5	174.8
Session FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Legislator Controls[b]	No	Yes	No	Yes
District Controls[c]	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,424	1,424	1,424	1,424

Notes: Same specifications, controls, exposure definitions, standard-error clustering, and significance thresholds as Table 12. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by district. The outcome is whether a legislator spoke during ERA debates.

Table 14: Legislators' Similarity to PSR: Illinois House (1972–1980)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: TV + FM				
CBS TV	0.159***	0.165***	0.174***	0.171***
	(0.035)	(0.040)	(0.043)	(0.047)
PBS TV	0.069*	0.073**	0.065*	0.067**
	(0.035)	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.033)
ABC TV	-0.107**	-0.130***	-0.192***	-0.200***
	(0.040)	(0.042)	(0.051)	(0.050)
NBC TV	-0.075*	-0.067	-0.081	-0.070
	(0.044)	(0.045)	(0.057)	(0.056)
CBS FM	-0.015	-0.010	-0.064***	-0.057**
	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.024)	(0.024)
Adjusted R^2	0.049	0.096	0.093	0.118
Panel B: TV + AM (OLS)				
CBS TV	0.151***	0.156***	0.188***	0.179***
	(0.036)	(0.040)	(0.046)	(0.048)
CBS AM	-0.025	-0.045	-0.035	-0.056
	(0.060)	(0.055)	(0.057)	(0.053)
Panel C: TV + AM (IV)				
CBS TV	0.173***	0.180***	0.204***	0.196***
	(0.024)	(0.029)	(0.044)	(0.045)
CBS AM	0.077**	0.073**	0.183**	0.168**
	(0.035)	(0.034)	(0.077)	(0.078)
First-stage F	332.3	357.3	210.6	235.3
Session FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Legislator Controls[b]	No	Yes	No	Yes
District Controls[c]	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,435	2,435	2,435	2,435

Notes: Same specifications, controls, exposure definitions, standard-error clustering, and significance thresholds as Table 12. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by district. The outcome is semantic similarity between legislators' ERA speeches and the relevant *Phyllis Schlafly Report* issue; the sample consists of speech-newsletter pairs for legislators who spoke.

Table 15: Signal Coverage Variation and Effect Sizes by Outcome

	Observation-Level				District-Level				Scaled Effects	
Network	N	SD	10th	90th	N	SD	10th	90th	$\hat{\beta} \times 1\,\text{SD}$	$\hat{\beta} \times$ Gap
Voting										
CBS TV	521	0.228	0.434	1.000	55	0.245	0.432	1.000	−0.032	−0.080
CBS FM	521	0.464	0.000	1.000	55	0.476	0.000	1.000	−0.184***	−0.397***
CBS AM (OLS)	521	0.243	0.153	0.694	55	0.258	0.156	0.734	−0.070	−0.167
CBS AM (IV)	521	0.298	0.185	0.907	55	0.290	0.189	0.907	0.066	0.159
Speaking										
CBS TV	1424	0.248	0.366	1.000	59	0.240	0.461	1.000	−0.001	−0.003
CBS FM	1424	0.465	0.000	1.000	59	0.474	0.000	1.000	−0.036	−0.077
CBS AM (OLS)	1424	0.240	0.146	0.722	59	0.252	0.149	0.654	−0.054**	−0.113**
CBS AM (IV)	1424	0.298	0.185	0.907	59	0.301	0.212	0.907	0.024	0.057
Similarity										
CBS TV	2435	0.255	0.318	1.000	55	0.258	0.379	1.000	0.044***	0.106***
CBS FM	2435	0.470	0.000	1.000	55	0.467	0.000	1.000	−0.027**	−0.057**
CBS TV	2435	0.255	0.318	1.000	55	0.258	0.379	1.000	0.050***	0.122***
CBS AM (IV)	2435	0.312	0.173	0.907	55	0.305	0.189	0.907	0.053**	0.121**

Notes: Gap = 90th percentile − 10th percentile. $\hat{\beta} \times 1\,\text{SD}$ uses the observation-level standard deviation. $\hat{\beta} \times$ Gap uses the district-level 10th–90th gap. $\hat{\beta}$ comes from the full specification with session fixed effects, legislator controls, district controls, TV network controls, and district-clustered standard errors. Stars reproduce the significance levels from the corresponding full-specification coefficient: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table 16: Specification Controls for Illinois General Assembly

	Voting	Speaking	Similarity
Panel A: TV + FM (OLS)			
CBS TV	-0.141	-0.005	0.171***
	(0.259)	(0.104)	(0.047)
CBS FM	-0.397***	-0.077	-0.057**
	(0.110)	(0.073)	(0.024)
1964 Goldwater %	-0.002	-0.004	0.000
	(0.006)	(0.003)	(0.001)
1970 Constitution No %	-0.006	-0.004**	-0.001
	(0.004)	(0.002)	(0.001)
JBS Member	-0.059	-0.033	0.010
	(0.117)	(0.041)	(0.022)
Legislator distance to JBS (mi)	-0.001	-0.000	-0.001**
	(0.004)	(0.002)	(0.001)
District Catholic %	0.023	0.003	0.006
	(0.039)	(0.008)	(0.005)
District Evangelical %	0.030	0.003	0.008
	(0.041)	(0.008)	(0.006)
District Mainline Protestant %	0.010	0.005	0.005
	(0.041)	(0.009)	(0.006)
District Other Christian %	0.143*	-0.002	0.013
	(0.080)	(0.014)	(0.013)
Republican	-0.344***	0.002	0.038**
	(0.087)	(0.033)	(0.014)
Female	0.095	0.381***	0.020
	(0.104)	(0.076)	(0.018)
Veteran	-0.199***	0.038*	-0.013
	(0.073)	(0.021)	(0.014)
Insurance Industry Affiliation	0.069	-0.028	0.012
	(0.126)	(0.040)	(0.023)
Catholic	-0.151*	0.024	0.013
	(0.085)	(0.029)	(0.018)
Jewish	0.127	0.039	0.055**
	(0.087)	(0.081)	(0.027)
Protestant	0.030	0.108**	-0.012
	(0.131)	(0.047)	(0.021)
Other Christian	0.124	0.186*	0.001
	(0.122)	(0.103)	(0.022)
Adjusted R^2	0.419	0.141	0.118
Panel B: TV + AM (SiO_2 IV)			
CBS AM	0.221	0.081	0.168**
	(0.373)	(0.191)	(0.078)
First-stage F	168.0	174.8	235.3
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	521	1,424	2,435

Notes: Full-specification control estimates. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by district. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Legislator reference categories are Democrat, Non-Veteran, No Religion, Male, and Non-Insurance. Insurance Affiliation = 1 if the legislator's industry involves insurance.

Table 17: Sensitivity to Signal Threshold (Illinois House)

	Strong[a]	Medium[b]	Weak[c]
ERA Vote			
CBS TV	-0.141	-0.670**	2.379***
	(0.259)	(0.317)	(0.763)
CBS FM	-0.397***	-0.288**	-0.199*
	(0.110)	(0.110)	(0.110)
CBS AM IV	0.221	0.192	0.369
	(0.373)	(0.388)	(0.331)
First-stage F	168.0	147.4	137.6
Speaking on ERA			
CBS TV	-0.005	0.042	-0.774***
	(0.104)	(0.116)	(0.274)
CBS FM	-0.077	-0.080	-0.082
	(0.073)	(0.067)	(0.075)
CBS AM IV	0.081	0.054	0.114
	(0.191)	(0.195)	(0.227)
First-stage F	174.8	166.8	171.4
Similarity to PSR			
CBS TV	0.171***	0.260***	-0.154
	(0.047)	(0.049)	(0.129)
CBS FM	-0.057**	-0.039*	-0.060***
	(0.024)	(0.022)	(0.021)
CBS AM IV	0.168**	0.133*	0.127
	(0.078)	(0.074)	(0.079)
First-stage F	235.3	175.7	133.0
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Legislator Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
District Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes

[a] **Strong** TV: −55 dBm (Robust reception; aligns with High VHF Grade B, 56 dBu, 47 CFR §73.683); FM: −47 dBm (FM city grade contour, 70 dBu, 47 CFR §73.315).
[b] **Medium** TV: −63 dBm (Primary service boundary; aligns with Low VHF Grade B, 47 dBu, 47 CFR §73.683); FM: −57 dBm (FM service contour, 60 dBu, 47 CFR §73.213).
[c] **Weak** TV: −75 dBm (Fringe reception limit); FM: −77 dBm (FM co-channel interfering contour, 40 dBu, 47 CFR §73.213).
Note: AM is a continuous z-scored measure and its definition does not change across columns. Its variation across columns reflects changes in the definition of the TV control variable. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by district. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table 18: Speaker Counterfactual: Votes Flipped by Removing CBS FM Exposure

Historical Chamber Context						**Speaker Sample**				
Sess.	Date	Req.	Y–N	Margin	Result	n	Y–N	(Nay Vote) Mean Exp.	Flips	99% CI
77H	1972-05-16	89	73–69	-16	FAIL	22	10–12	43.7%	2	[1–4]
77H	1972-06-15	107	82–76	-25	FAIL	47	23–24	32.0%	3	[1–5]
78H	1973-04-04	107	95–72	-12	FAIL	56	29–27	48.3%	5	[1–9]
79H	1975-05-01	107	113–62	+6	PASS	76	50–26	44.9%	5	[1–8]
80H	1977-06-02	107	101–74	-6	FAIL	86	53–33	40.8%	5	[2–9]
80H	1978-06-07	107	101–64	-6	FAIL	80	52–28	43.8%	5	[1–8]
80H	1978-06-22	107	105–71	-2	FAIL	85	55–30	40.9%	5	[1–8]
81H	1980-06-18	107	102–71	-5	FAIL	69	41–28	34.3%	4	[1–7]
Total			**772–559**	**-66**		**521**	**313–208**		**34**	**[10–58]**

Since $\beta < 0$, removing exposure in the counterfactual increases the likelihood of a Yes vote.
Each Nay legislator who spoke has flip probability $|\beta| \times \text{Exposure}_i$, where $\beta = -0.397$ (SE: 0.110), the full-specification CBS FM coefficient from Table 12.
The May 1972 vote required a simple majority but all subsequent votes required a 3/5 majority.

Table 19: Data Sources

Source	Coverage	Records	Use
Panel A: Digitized Data			
Treatment			
1972–73 Television Factbook	National (1972)	All TV stations	Tower parameters
1972 Broadcasting Yearbook	National (1971)	CBS AM/FM stations	Tower parameters
CBS Morning News transcripts[a]	1974	14 Schlafly appearances	Treatment validation
Outcomes			
IL House votes[b]	1972–1980	8 sessions, 521 votes	Vote
IL House debates[c]	1972–1980	8 sessions, 521 speeches	Similarity
P. Schlafly Report (Eagle Forum)	1972–1980	21 ERA newsletters	Similarity
P. Schlafly Report (Legacy DVD)	1972–1980	60 ERA newsletters	Similarity robustness
Controls			
IL Blue Books	1972–1980	Legislator bios	Legislator controls
IL Official Vote, 1964	State	County/town/ward returns	Goldwater % control
IL Official Vote, 1970	State	County/town/ward returns	Constitution % control
John Birch Society membership[d]	1964–1974	Dues paid before 1972	Conservative network control
Maps			
IL House legislative districts	77th, 78th+ sessions	2 GIS shapefiles	Legislative boundaries
Panel B: Existing Data			
Outcome			
American National Election Studies (ANES)	1970–1984	Individual responses	Public opinion poll
Controls			
Association of Religion Data Archives (ARDA)	1971	County church membership	Religious composition
Maps			
USGS National Elevation Dataset	National	30m resolution	Quasi-random FM/TV variation
FCC Ground Conductivity (M3)	National	Conductivity (S/m)	Endogenous AM soil
USGS Geochemical Survey[e]	National	SiO_2 concentration	AM instrumental
US counties	National	GIS shapefile	County boundaries

[a] CBS transcripts accessed on microfilm/fiches. No transcripts located outside 1974 CBS Morning News.

[b] Digitized from Newspapers.com: Chicago Tribune, Daily Calumet, Daily Chronicle, Daily Herald, Decatur Daily, Dispatch, Dixon, Edwardsville Intelligencer, Herald, Herald & Review, Pantagraph, Southern Illinoisan, and News Journal.

[c] Transcribed from Illinois General Assembly records mandated by Article IV, 1970 IL Constitution.

[d] Recovered office lists and index cards with names, addresses, and dues records. Geocoded to county and legislative district.

[e] USGS National Geochemical Survey, interpolated silicon dioxide (SiO_2) concentration raster. SiO_2 is geologically exogenous and predicts soil conductivity, providing an instrument for AM signal variation uncorrelated with political preferences.

Table 20: Signal Propagation Model Parameters

Parameter	Description	TV	FM	AM
Propagation Model				
Model	Propagation engine	ITM[a]	ITM[a]	LFMF[b]
Mode	Operational mode	Point-to-Point	Area Prediction	Millington[c]
Antenna & Siting				
h_r	Receiver height (m)	9.0	2.0	0.0[d]
Gain	Receiver antenna gain (dBi)	0.0	−4.0	—
Polarization	Antenna polarization	Horizontal (0)	Vertical (1)	Vertical
TX Siting	Transmitter siting criteria	—	Careful (1)	—
RX Siting	Receiver siting criteria	—	Random (0)	—
Environment & Climate				
N_s	Surface refractivity (N-units)	301.0	301.0	301.0
Climate	Climate code	5	5	—
ϵ	Ground relative permittivity	15.0	15.0	FCC M3[e]
σ	Ground conductivity (S/m)	0.005	0.005	FCC M3[e]
Statistical Reliability				
mdvar	Mode of variability	Broadcast (3)	Mobile (2)	—
Time	Time availability (%)	50.0	50.0	—
Location	Location availability (%)	50.0	50.0	—
Situation	Situation confidence (%)	50.0	50.0	—
Terrain / Path Data				
Resolution	Elevation profile points	1000	1000	—
Terrain radius	Δh computation radius (km)	—	30	—
Path segments	Millington path segments	—	—	50[f]
Max distance	Maximum TX–RX distance (km)	—	—	800

[a] Irregular Terrain Model (Longley–Rice); parameters from Hufford, Longley, and Kissick 1982. FM receiver nets to −4.0 dBi (−3.0 dBi mobile antenna whip −1.0 dB line losses). TV receiver nets to 0 dBi (+2.0 dBi antenna gain −2.0 dB line losses). Siting criteria is a qualitative description (0, 1, or 2) of the care taken to choose a terminal site specifically to improve radio reception.

[b] AM signals (0.5–1.7 MHz) propagate via ground wave, not line-of-sight, so terrain elevation is irrelevant. Attenuation depends on soil conductivity properties (σ, ϵ) along the path.

[c] Millington method averages forward and reverse path field strength to handle mixed-conductivity ground. Each TX–RX path is divided into 50 segments; each segment's σ and ϵ are looked up from the FCC M3 conductivity map (or SiO_2 raster for the IV).

[d] LFMF receiver height fixed at ground level (0 m). Transmitter height uses station records, defaulting to 60 m if missing or invalid (<10 m), and dynamically capped at 0.7λ per LFMF specifications.

[e] FCC Ground Conductivity Map (M3): spatially varying σ (S/m) and ϵ digitized from FCC records. The LFMF parameters are endogenous because soil conductivity correlates with agricultural land use patterns. Residualized SiO_2: IV = LFMF(σ from SiO_2) − LFMF(σ = 0.005). Silicon dioxide concentration is geologically determined and uncorrelated with political preferences but predicts soil conductivity variation affecting AM signal propagation.

[f] TX–RX path divided into 50 equal-length segments. Conductivity and permittivity sampled at midpoint of each segment.